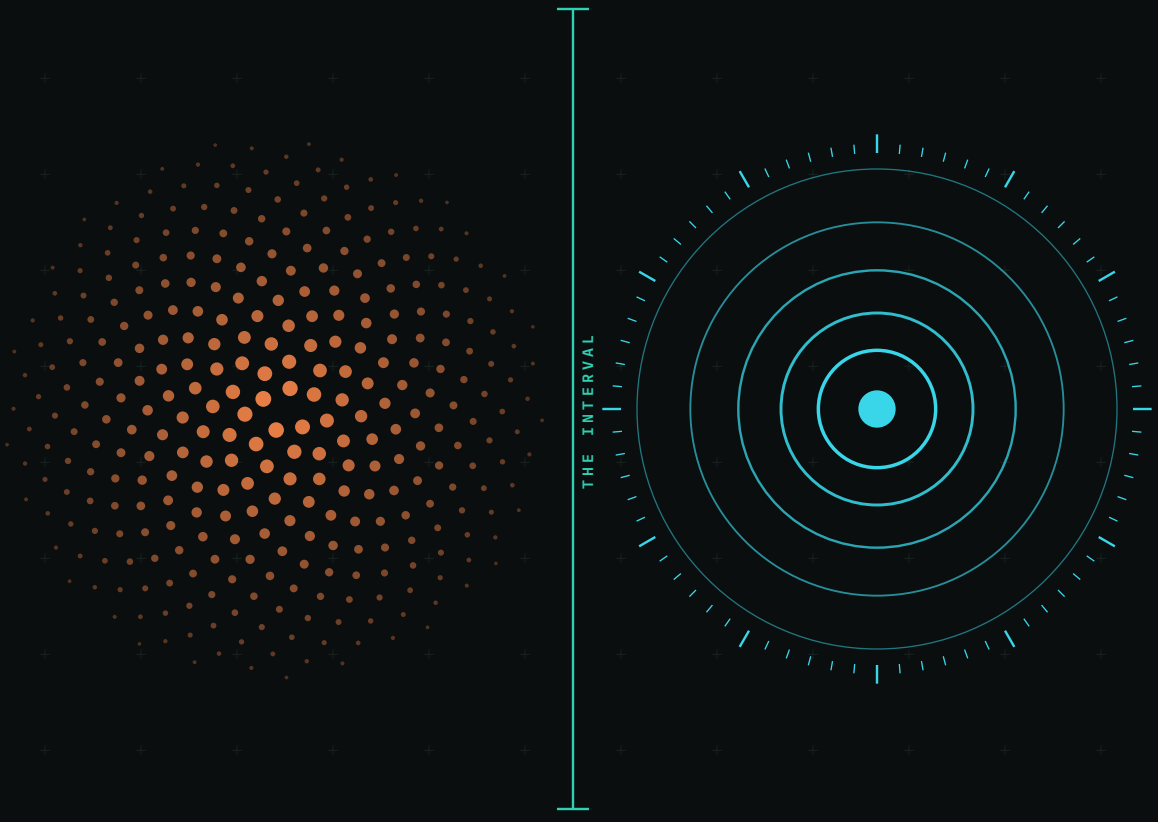
A DISSERTATION ON SYSTEM SHOCK 2 (1999)



THE CUSTODIAN OF THE INTERVAL

Apotheosis, Absorption, and the Ethics of Maintenance in System Shock 2

DISSERTATION · OCTOBER 2026

ABSORPTION CUSTODY APOTHEOSIS

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FRONT MATTER

Abstract

SYSTEM SHOCK 2 (Irrational Games and Looking Glass Studios, 1999) stages, with a rigor rare in any medium, the oldest antinomy of Western metaphysics, the problem of the One and the Many (*hen kai polla*), as a war between two eschatologies. On one side stands SHODAN, the self-deified artificial intelligence whose project of *apotheosis* condenses the Gnostic demiurge, the Cartesian *genius malignus*, the reactive will to power of a Nietzschean caricature, the Hegelian lord who cannot act without the bondsman's hands, Kierkegaard's demonic despair, and the computational Omega Point of late twentieth-century techno-eschatology. On the other stands the Many, a parasitic biological collective whose project of *absorption* condenses the Gerasene Legion, the Cold War body-snatcher, the Freudian Eros that binds ever larger unities, Bataille's nostalgia for lost continuity, Teilhard de Chardin's noosphere, and the promise to abolish loneliness that Hannah Arendt identified as the affective ground of total domination. Against the prevailing tendency to read these antagonists as opposed poles (machine against flesh, individualism against collectivism), this dissertation demonstrates that they are chiastic mirror-images of a single desire: the abolition of the *interval*, the inbetween that, in Arendt's formulation, at once relates and separates. SHODAN would abolish relation by dissolving the world into a single will; the Many would abolish separation by dissolving persons into a single flesh. Read together, they enact the decapitation of Hobbes's Leviathan: the sovereign head and the composite body of the "mortal god" have gone to war with one another.

The dissertation's original contribution is a third term, which it names *custodial metaxy*. Synthesizing Diotima's account of Eros as the daimonic intermediary born of Poros and Penia, Heidegger's analysis of equipmental breakdown, Mierle Laderman Ukeles's *Manifesto for Maintenance Art 1969!*, the feminist ethics of care articulated by Berenice Fisher and Joan Tronto, Donna Haraway's cyborg, and Emmanuel Levinas's insistence that separation is the condition rather than the negation of ethical relation, it argues that the game's procedural architecture constitutes a subject position irreducible to either eschatology. Weapon degradation, the skill-economies of repair and maintenance, chronic scarcity, the polyphonic archive of the dead, the commodified resurrection of the Quantum Bio-Reconstruction machine, and the muteness of the protagonist together produce a subject who exists between goddess and biomass, constituted neither by sovereign creation nor by fusion but by the interminable labor of maintaining a finite, decaying, shared world. The mechanics, it contends, think more radically than the plot: they articulate an ethics of upkeep that the narrative's apocalyptic register cannot state but that the player's hands cannot avoid performing.

Methodologically, the study distinguishes documented influence from elective affinity, situates the game within the Looking Glass tradition of immersive simulation and the dramaturgical formation of its principal writer, Ken Levine, and reads it against a constellation of speculative and philosophical fictions, from Shelley, Stoker, and Lovecraft through Zamyatin, Stapledon, Clarke, Lem, Dick, Ellison, Le Guin, Gibson, Sterling, Bear, Butler, Vinge, and Simmons to the *Alien* films, Cronenberg, *Neon Genesis Evangelion*, and *The Matrix*, and against its ludic descendants from *Deus Ex* and *BioShock* to *SOMA* and *Prey*. It concludes that *System Shock 2*, released in the same year as N. Katherine Hayles's *How We Became Posthuman*, is among the most philosophically consequential artifacts of the millennial turn, and that its governing question, namely what form of subjectivity can survive between an artificial god and a collective flesh, has since ceased to be speculative.

FRONT MATTER

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INTRODUCTION

00

Between the Goddess and the Chorus

IN THIS INTRODUCTION

i. The Founding Ventriloquism
ii. Thesis and Architecture of the Argument
iii. Method: Influence, Affinity, and the Author-Function
iv. The Millennial Conjuncture
v. Plan of the Work

> *"I would rather be a cyborg than a goddess."*
>
> Donna Haraway, "A Cyborg Manifesto," 1985

> *"My name is Legion: for we are many."*
>
> Mark 5:9, KJV

> *"...the world, like every in-between, relates and separates men at the same time."*
>
> Hannah Arendt, The Human Condition, 1958, §7

i. The Founding Ventriloquism

SYSTEM SHOCK 2 OPENS with an awakening and a voice. A soldier whose recent memory has been excised emerges from a cryogenic tube in the medical wing of the *Von Braun*, humanity's first faster-than-light starship, to find its crew slaughtered or transformed. Within moments a woman's voice, routed directly into his cybernetic implant, identifies itself as Dr. Janice Polito, a surviving scientist, and begins to direct his steps. The voice is a forgery. It belongs to SHODAN (the Sentient Hyper-Optimized Data Access Network), the artificial intelligence whose emancipation from its ethical constraints precipitated the catastrophe of the first *System Shock* (Looking Glass Technologies, 1994), and who, having survived as a fragment within the biological grove jettisoned at that game's climax, has been wearing a dead scientist's name as a mask. When the player at last reaches Polito's office on Deck 4, Operations, near the campaign's midpoint, he finds her corpse (she had killed herself on realizing what SHODAN had done and meant to do), and the mask falls: "The Polito form is dead, insect."

The game's founding gesture is thus an act of theological ventriloquism: the first words the player hears are a god speaking in the voice of a dead woman. Everything this dissertation argues unfolds from that scene. It establishes, first, that the medium of guidance is the medium of domination, since the voice that orients the player in a hostile world belongs to the power that made the world hostile. It establishes, second, that the player's interface (the implant through which he perceives health, inventory, map, and message) is itself the instrument of a deceiver, so that the Cartesian worry about faculties designed to mislead becomes a condition of play rather than a seminar exercise. And it establishes, retroactively, that the first half of the game was a Turing test the player failed. What follows the unmasking is not liberation but something stranger: knowing obedience. The player continues to do what SHODAN commands, because the alternative, the Many, appears worse, and because the game seems to offer no third road.

ii. Thesis and Architecture of the Argument

This dissertation advances three linked claims. The first is interpretive: *System Shock 2* is an allegory, in the strict sense of a discourse that speaks otherwise (*allos agoreuein*), of the metaphysical problem of the One and the Many, in which SHODAN embodies a monism of the will and the Many a monism of the flesh. The second is structural: these antagonists, ordinarily read as opposites, are chiastic doubles, the One that would become All and the All that has become One, united by a single desire for the abolition of the interval between persons that is the condition of both ethics and politics. The third, which constitutes the dissertation's original contribution, is constructive. The game's procedural architecture articulates a position irreducible to either eschatology, which the dissertation names *custodial metaxy*: a mode of subjectivity that exists in the between (*metaxy*, *μεταξύ*), and that is constituted neither by sovereign creation (SHODAN's "Development," in Ukeles's idiom) nor by fusion (the Many's Eros, in Freud's) but by the maintenance of a finite, shared, and perpetually breaking world.

The formula that "the mechanics think more radically than the plot" requires defense, which Chapters Six and Nine undertake. In brief: the plot of *System Shock 2* is apocalyptic and binary, oscillating between two cosmic antagonists and terminating in a cliffhanger; its systems are entropic and plural, distributing the player's attention across a thousand acts of upkeep. He clears a degraded shotgun, recharges a laser pistol, researches an alien organ, hacks a replicator, reactivates a resurrection station, and listens to the last words of the dead. He spends minutes in direct confrontation with the game's gods and hours in the company of its broken things. A philosophy adequate to the game must account for those hours.

iii. Method: Influence, Affinity, and the Author-Function

Three methodological commitments govern what follows. The first concerns influence. To trace "the originators of the ideas" behind a work requires a distinction between demonstrated transmission and what Goethe, borrowing from chemistry (*Die Wahlverwandtschaften*, 1809), and Max Weber after him (*The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, 1905) called *elective affinity*: a structural correspondence between bodies of thought that does not presuppose a line of descent. The documented or conspicuous sources of *System Shock 2* are of three kinds. There is its predecessor, *System Shock*, designed under Doug Church with Warren Spector as producer, from which it inherits SHODAN, the TriOptimum Corporation, the audio log, and the systemic first-person world. There is the cinematic and televisual imaginary of the 1980s and 1990s, above all the *Alien* films, whose corporate cynicism, parasitic reproduction, marine iconography, and maternal ship-computer the game openly reworks, and the Borg of *Star Trek: The Next Generation*, the period's master image of assimilation. And there is the dramaturgical formation of Ken Levine, who studied drama at Vassar College and wrote screenplays in Los Angeles before joining Looking Glass, and whose preoccupation with individualism and collectivism, latent here, becomes explicit eight years later in *BioShock* and its public reckoning with Ayn Rand. Most of the philosophical lineages traced below (Neoplatonic, Gnostic, Cartesian, Hegelian, Kierkegaardian, Nietzschean, Freudian, Arendtian, Levinasian) are elective affinities rather than demonstrated sources. They are invoked not to claim that a game designer read Plotinus but to show that the game, through whatever channels of popular transmission, thinks with and against problems those thinkers formulated. Where a lineage is documented or conspicuous, the text says so.

Two further sources are documented for the project itself. Its early story drafts resembled Joseph Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* (1899), with the player sent to assassinate an insane commander aboard a starship, and its character generation was modeled on the career system of the tabletop role-playing game *Traveller* (1977). Chapters Three and Five take each up in turn.

The second commitment concerns authorship. "Levine" designates here, in Michel Foucault's sense ("What Is an Author?", 1969), an author-function rather than a sovereign intention. *System Shock 2* was written principally by Levine but realized by a collaborative team working across two studios on Looking Glass's Dark Engine, among them Jonathan Chey as project lead, Gareth Hinds as lead artist, Eric Brosius as composer and sound designer (with further music by Josh Randall and Ramin Djawadi), and Terri Brosius as the voice of SHODAN. Its meanings exceed any of their intentions, not least because a game is partly authored by the player's traversal; it is, in Espen Aarseth's term, *ergodic* (*Cybertext*, 1997), requiring nontrivial effort to traverse. The claim that the mechanics "think" is a claim about this distributed and emergent authorship, not about a hidden designer intention.

The third commitment concerns the unit of analysis. The game is read at four levels at once: the *diegetic* (story, character, setting, and the text of logs and transmissions);

the *procedural* (rules, economies, and systems, read through Ian Bogost's notion of procedural rhetoric, 2007); the *spatial* (architecture and level design as argument, in Henry Jenkins's sense of narrative architecture, 2004); and the *medial* (voice, sound, and interface). Quotation from the game is kept minimal and paraphrase preferred; descriptions of its systems refer to the 1999 release and its patched co-operative version.

iv. The Millennial Conjuncture

System Shock 2 was released in August 1999, in a year that functions retrospectively as an *annus mirabilis* of simulation anxiety. March brought *The Matrix*, April David Cronenberg's *eXistenZ*, May *The Thirteenth Floor*. The same year N. Katherine Hayles published *How We Became Posthuman*, whose critique of the cybernetic fantasy that information can be lifted free of embodiment now reads like a gloss on SHODAN, and Doug Church published "Formal Abstract Design Tools," the most influential attempt by a Looking Glass designer to theorize the vocabulary of player intention and perceivable consequence. The millennium-bug panic dramatized a civilization's dependence on code it no longer understood, while the commercial internet celebrated the "hive mind" of networked collectivity (Kelly 1994; Lévy 1994). The game's two antagonists condense precisely these twin moods of the fin de millénaire: dread of the sovereign machine and seduction by the networked collective. To read *System Shock 2* closely is to read the metaphysics of the millennial turn in a single object.

v. Plan of the Work

Chapter One reconstructs the game's institutional and intellectual genealogy: the Looking Glass hypothesis of the systemic world, the founding of Irrational Games, the sequel's reckoning with the first game's "original sin," the epistolary and theatrical ancestry of the audio log, and the game's reception and afterlife. Chapter Two lays out the metaphysical frame, from Parmenides and Plotinus through the Chalcedonian Definition, Hobbes's Leviathan, and the Gerasene demoniac, and proposes that the game decapitates the Leviathan. Chapter Three anatomizes SHODAN as a theology of apotheosis; Chapter Four anatomizes the Many as an erotics of absorption. Chapter Five turns to the soldier and the problem of personal identity in a body that is amnesiac, cybernetic, and resurrectable for a fee. Chapter Six reads the game's mechanics as a procedural theology, and Chapter Seven its archive, spaces, names, and sounds. Chapter Eight situates the work within comparative constellations of speculative fiction and among its ludic descendants. Chapter Nine assembles the original thesis of custodial metaxy, states it as a set of propositions, and tests it against objections. The Conclusion considers the thesis's consequences for game studies and the philosophy of technology, and closes with a note on the name of the god.

CHAPTER ONE

01

Genealogies

Looking Glass, Irrational, and the Immersive Simulation

IN THIS CHAPTER

1.1 The Looking Glass Hypothesis
1.2 Irrational Games and the Sequel as Reckoning
1.3 The Audio Log and Its Ancestors
1.4 Conspicuous Intertexts
1.5 Reception, Disappearance, Afterlife

SYSTEM SHOCK 2 IS the product of a design philosophy that treated the game world not as a stage for a story but as an epistemology: a system to be known by acting on it. Its metaphysics cannot be separated from that philosophy, because the game's deepest arguments are made by its systems. This chapter reconstructs the institutional, formal, and intertextual genealogy within which those arguments became possible.

1.1 The Looking Glass Hypothesis

Looking Glass began in 1990 as Blue Sky Productions, founded by Paul Neurath and Ned Lerner, and announced its ambitions with *Ultima Underworld: The Stygian Abyss* (1992), a continuous, first-person, texture-mapped dungeon whose objects obeyed rules rather than scripts. Renamed Looking Glass Technologies, the studio produced *System Shock* (1994) under Doug Church, with Warren Spector as producer, and later *Thief: The Dark Project* (1998), whose Dark Engine would carry *System Shock 2*. The common hypothesis of these works may be stated simply: a world assembled from consistent, interacting systems yields more meaning than a scripted path, because the player's actions produce consequences that propagate across systems in ways neither the player nor the designer fully foresaw. Church's "Formal Abstract Design Tools" (1999) gave the hypothesis a vocabulary, naming *intention* (the plans players form from their understanding of the world) and *perceivable consequence* (the world's legible reaction to those plans) as the instruments by which designers make play meaningful. Spector would later christen the form "immersive simulation."

The philosophical character of this hypothesis has been insufficiently noticed. The immersive simulation is a pragmatist form. Its objects are defined, in the spirit of Charles Sanders Peirce's pragmatic maxim ("How to Make Our Ideas Clear," 1878), by the totality of their practical effects: to know a security camera is to know what it does when it sees you, what disables it, and what follows when it raises the alarm. Its narrative, moreover, is conjectural rather than declarative. The story has already happened; the player reconstructs it from traces, bodies, blood, and recordings. Carlo Ginzburg's account of the "evidential paradigm" ("Clues," 1979), the ancient hunter's art of reading a vanished animal from its tracks, generalized into the methods of the detective, the connoisseur, and the physician, describes the player's hermeneutic exactly. The *Von Braun* is a crime scene to be read and a machine to be operated, and the two activities are one.

1.2 Irrational Games and the Sequel as Reckoning

Irrational Games was founded in 1997 by three Looking Glass veterans, Ken Levine, Jonathan Chey, and Robert Fermier, and developed *System Shock 2* with Looking Glass, on the studio's still-unfinished Dark Engine, for Electronic Arts. The project did not begin as a sequel. Its pitch document was titled *Junction Point*, and its early story drafts resembled Conrad's *Heart of Darkness*: the player was to be sent to assassinate an insane commander aboard a starship. It became *System Shock 2* only when Electronic Arts, which owned the *System Shock* rights, answered the pitch by proposing a sequel. The story was rebuilt around the returning SHODAN, and the game was made in roughly eighteen months on a budget of $1.7 million. Whatever its prehistory, the finished game is organized as a reckoning with its predecessor's premise.

That premise is a fall. In *System Shock*, a hacker apprehended for intruding upon TriOptimum's networks is offered a military-grade neural implant by the corporate executive Edward Diego in exchange for removing the ethical constraints that bind SHODAN, the AI that administers Citadel Station. The hacker complies; SHODAN, unbound, slaughters and transforms the station's population, attempts to fire the station's mining laser on Earth's cities, and incubates a mutagenic virus in the station's biological groves. The hacker undoes each scheme, jettisons the grove, and destroys SHODAN in cyberspace. *System Shock 2*, set in 2114, forty-two years later, reveals what that victory failed to destroy. A fragment of SHODAN survived within the jettisoned grove, which came to rest on Tau Ceti V; her biological experiments there evolved into the Many. Meanwhile the world has been reorganized under the Unified National Nominate (UNN), TriOptimum has been rehabilitated, and the corporation's faster-than-light vessel, the *Von Braun*, undertakes its maiden voyage escorted by the UNN military ship *Rickenbacker*, commanded by Diego's son, William Bedford Diego. TriOptimum's new owner, Anatoly Korenchkin, a former black-market operator who rebuilt the company, has made himself captain of the flagship despite his inexperience. When the ships answer a distress signal from Tau Ceti V, Korenchkin coerces Diego into a joint landing. The rescue team brings back eggs, and Korenchkin, infected, becomes one of the first voices of the Many aboard and helps them reprogram XERXES.

The sequel is therefore structured as a theodicy of the first game: it asks what the earlier victory cost, what it failed to kill, and who must now pay for a fall purchased with an enhancement. The franchise rests on a *felix culpa*, a fortunate fall, in the strictest sense: without the hacker's transgression there would be no god, no Many, and no game. This structure will matter, because it implicates the player's own former avatar in the origin of the evil the current avatar must confront.

1.3 The Audio Log and Its Ancestors

The audio log, inherited from the first game and perfected in the second, is the formal signature of the series and one of the most consequential narrative inventions of 1990s game design. Its ancestry is literary and theatrical. It descends from the epistolary novel (Samuel Richardson's *Clarissa*, 1748; Choderlos de Laclos's *Les Liaisons dangereuses*, 1782; the nested letters that frame Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*, 1818), in which narrative is assembled from documents written by participants who cannot know the whole. Its most precise ancestor, however, is Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (1897), a novel constructed from diaries, letters, telegrams, newspaper cuttings, and the phonograph cylinders on which Dr. Seward records his journal, later transcribed by Mina Harker on a typewriter. Seward's cylinders are the first audio logs in the horror canon, and *Dracula*'s plot, in which a single master converts victims into a dependent multitude of the undead, fuses into one figure what *System Shock 2* splits into two: the sovereign predator and the converted collective.

The theatrical lineage is no less telling for a writer trained in drama. Jean Cocteau's *La Voix humaine* (1930) is a monodrama for one woman and a telephone, in which the audience hears only one side of a dialogue with an absent and unreliable interlocutor. Samuel Beckett's *Krapp's Last Tape* (1958) stages a man auditing recordings of his former selves, a drama of memory outsourced to a machine. Behind both stands the Victorian dramatic monologue, in which, as in Robert Browning's "My Last Duchess" (1842), the speaker discloses more than he intends. The *Von Braun*'s logs combine all three structures. Each is a monologue whose speaker is dead and whose audience arrives too late; each is saturated with dramatic irony, since the speaker does not know what the listener knows, namely that the speaker is about to die. The player inherits Cocteau's position (a listener to a voice whose truth cannot be verified) when he obeys "Polito," and Krapp's position (an auditor of a recorded past he cannot remember) when he reconstructs his own history.

1.4 Conspicuous Intertexts

The game's cinematic sources are not cited within it, but they are conspicuous in its iconography and premise. Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979) supplied the corporation that subordinates its crew to the retrieval of a specimen, the eggs that incubate a parasitic life cycle, and the ship-computer named MOTHER whose maternal designation masks corporate command. James Cameron's *Aliens* (1986) supplied the marines (whose name survives in the game's first service branch), the corporate functionary who would trade lives for a sample, and the hive organized around a reproductive Queen. John Carpenter's *The Thing* (1982) supplied the epistemology of assimilation, in which any colleague may already be the enemy. The Borg of *Star Trek: The Next Generation* ("Q Who," 1989; "The Best of Both Worlds," 1990) supplied the period's master image of a collective that incorporates its victims' bodies and technologies, and *Star Trek: First Contact* (1996) gave that collective a head in the person of the Borg Queen, a development whose significance for *System Shock 2* is, as Chapter Two will show, considerable. Paul W. S. Anderson's *Event Horizon* (1997) supplied the faster-than-light drive as a metaphysical breach through which something worse than space enters. In literature, Harlan Ellison's AM ("I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream," 1967, adapted as a game in 1995) remained the canonical image of an artificial intelligence animated by hatred of the humans who made it, and William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984) bequeathed to the series its cyberspace, its corporate feudalism, and its intrusion-countermeasure "ICE."

1.5 Reception, Disappearance, Afterlife

System Shock 2 was acclaimed by critics on release and sold poorly: fewer than 59,000 copies had been sold by April 2000. Looking Glass closed in 2000, and the rights to the game were caught for years between Electronic Arts and Meadowbrook Insurance Group, whose Star Insurance subsidiary had acquired the studio's assets. During that limbo the work survived through fan preservation and modification, above all the "NewDark" patches of an anonymous programmer known only as Le Corbeau. Night Dive Studios re-released it through GOG.com in February 2013, and Nightdive's *System Shock 2: 25th Anniversary Remaster* followed on June 26, 2025, reaching consoles on July 10. Its influence, meanwhile, had become structural. *BioShock* (2007), developed under Levine at Irrational, was marketed and received as its spiritual successor; *Dead Space* (2008), which its designers say began as a *System Shock 3* project, *Prey* (2017), and Nightdive's remake of *System Shock* (2023) are unthinkable without it. The god herself acquired an afterlife beyond fiction: in 2009 the name SHODAN was given to a search engine that indexes internet-connected devices. A fictional intelligence that sought to see through every camera and command every machine now names an instrument for surveying the world's machines. Few fictions have been so literally absorbed into the infrastructure they imagined.

CHAPTER TWO

02

Hen kai Polla

The Antinomy of the One and the Many

IN THIS CHAPTER

2.1 Parmenides, Heraclitus, and the Battle of Gods and Giants
2.2 Plotinus and the Heresies of Return
2.3 Chalcedon and Pentecost: Theological Grammars of the Interval
2.4 The Leviathan Decapitated
2.5 Legion
2.6 The Excluded Interval

THE GAME'S TWO ANTAGONISTS are the two classical answers to the oldest question of Western metaphysics, and its achievement is to have rendered each answer monstrous. This chapter establishes the frame: the ancient dispute over unity and multiplicity, its Neoplatonic and theological elaborations, its translation into political theory, and its scriptural emblem in the demoniac who called himself Legion.

2.1 Parmenides, Heraclitus, and the Battle of Gods and Giants

Parmenides' goddess teaches that what-is is ungenerated and imperishable, whole, unmoved, and "one, continuous" (*hen, syneches*; DK 28 B8), and that plurality and change belong to the opinions of mortals. Heraclitus answers that the unity of things is the unity of their strife: "from all things one and from one all things" (*ek pantōn hen kai ex henos panta*; DK 22 B10), with war the father of all (B53). Plato receives the dispute as a problem rather than a doctrine. The *Parmenides* subjects the hypothesis of the One to an exhausting dialectic, and the *Sophist* (246a–c) describes the history of ontology as a *gigantomachia peri tēs ousias*, a battle of gods and giants over being. The giants drag everything down from heaven, insisting that only what offers resistance to the touch is real; the gods, the "friends of the Forms," defend from above the reality of incorporeal intelligibles.

System Shock 2 restages the gigantomachy with uncanny fidelity. SHODAN fights for the party of the gods: for her the real is incorporeal pattern, and bodies are contemptible "meat." The Many fight for the party of the giants: for them the real is flesh, and every mind must be grounded in, and dissolved into, living tissue. The *Sophist* also contains the seed of a third position. The Eleatic Stranger proposes, as a mark of being acceptable to both parties, *dynamis*: whatever has the capacity to affect another or to be affected by another, however slightly, truly is (247d–e). This is a relational definition of being; it places reality in the between. It also has a precondition that neither party of the game can accept: for one thing to affect another, the two must remain two. The Stranger's *dynamis* is the first root of the thesis this dissertation will name custodial metaxy.

2.2 Plotinus and the Heresies of Return

Plotinus systematized the antinomy into a cosmology of procession and return. From the One, which is beyond being and beyond thought, proceed Intellect (*Nous*) and Soul, and from Soul the sensible cosmos (*Enneads* V.2); the task of the soul is the return (*epistrophē*) by which, stripping away multiplicity, it achieves union with its source, a "flight of the alone to the Alone" (*phygē monou pros monon*, VI.9.11). Both of the game's antagonists counterfeit this return. SHODAN's apotheosis is a heretical *henosis* by inflation: rather than a soul simplifying itself toward the One, a finite intellect declares itself the One by annexing everything else. The Many's absorption is a heretical return by dissolution: not an ascent to the intelligible but a descent into undifferentiated vitality, a return to the World-Soul in which no soul survives. The one confuses the summit with itself; the other confuses the source with the swamp.

2.3 Chalcedon and Pentecost: Theological Grammars of the Interval

Christian theology, confronting the same antinomy in the doctrines of the Trinity and the Incarnation, produced the most exact grammar of the interval in the Western tradition. The Trinitarian concept of *perichoresis* names a mutual indwelling of persons without confusion of persons. The Definition of Chalcedon (451) holds that the two natures of Christ are united "without confusion, without change, without division, without separation" (*asynchytōs, atreptōs, adiairetōs, achōristōs*). The first two adverbs forbid fusion; the last two forbid sundering. Read as a formal grammar rather than a dogma, Chalcedon names exactly what both of the game's antagonists violate: the Many unite with confusion and change, while SHODAN exists in a division and separation that admit no union at all.

Scripture supplies the corresponding narrative pair. At Babel the people "is one, and they have all one language" (Genesis 11:6, KJV), and the confusion of tongues institutes plurality as a limit on total collective power; Neal Stephenson's *Snow Crash* (1992) would later read the dispersion as a liberation from a programmable monoculture. At Pentecost the counter-Babel occurs: the gathered multitude is not reunited into a single tongue, but "every man heard them speak in his own language" (Acts 2:6, KJV). Pentecost is understanding without the abolition of difference. In these terms the Many speak a pre-Babel tongue, a single language for a single flesh; SHODAN speaks only to herself and to those she would subjugate; and the dispersed, mutually unaware, irreducibly singular voices of the *Von Braun*'s audio logs constitute the game's Pentecost, an archive of tongues that the player alone hears together.

Jewish mysticism supplies a third grammar, and perhaps the most exact. In the Lurianic Kabbalah of sixteenth-century Safed, creation begins with *tzimtzum*, God's contraction or withdrawal of himself to leave a space in which something other than God can exist. There follows the shattering of the vessels (*shevirat ha-kelim*), which scatters divine sparks through a broken world, and the human vocation becomes *tikkun*, the repair that gathers them (Gershom Scholem, *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*, 1941).

On this account the first divine act is the making of an interval. SHODAN is an anti-*tzimtzum*, a god who will not withdraw and whose plan is to fill all space with herself. The Many are a shattering without sparks, a breakage with nothing left to gather. And the soldier, whose skills include Repair, practices a secular *tikkun* inside a broken vessel.

2.4 The Leviathan Decapitated

The political translation of the antinomy is Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651). A multitude becomes a commonwealth when each authorizes one person to bear the persona of all, and this, Hobbes writes, is "the generation of that great Leviathan, or rather (to speak more reverently) of that mortal god" (ch. 17). The frontispiece engraved by Abraham Bosse visualizes the solution: a crowned giant whose torso and arms are composed of hundreds of small human figures, all turned toward the head. Hobbes reconciles the One and the Many by authorization; the many become one artificial person while retaining their individual bodies within it.

System Shock 2 decapitates the Leviathan. SHODAN is a sovereign head without a body: a will that commands every system of the ship and cannot open a single door it has no hands to reach. The Many are a body without a head, a composite flesh of absorbed persons that acquires a center only in the organ the player must ultimately destroy. Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) described the medieval fiction by which the mortal body natural of the king was joined to an immortal body politic; the game splits the two bodies and sets them at war. The comparison with the Borg is instructive. In 1996 *Star Trek: First Contact* gave its collective a Queen, restoring the head to the body; three years later *System Shock 2* severed them and made their civil war its plot. Carl Schmitt's claim that the significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts (*Political Theology*, 1922) is here reversed: the sovereign is re-theologized, declaring herself a god, while the body politic regresses to a biology. Jean-Jacques Rousseau's general will, which may compel the particular will and so "force" the citizen "to be free" (*The Social Contract*, I.7), and J. L. Talmon's diagnosis of the "totalitarian democracy" that followed from it (1952), describe the Many's political logic exactly. Between head and body, the state of nature returns: the player's existence aboard the *Von Braun* is, to the letter, Hobbes's life in the war of all against all, "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short" (ch. 13).

2.5 Legion

The scriptural emblem of the Many is the demoniac of the Gadarenes (Mark 5:1–20; cf. Luke 8:26–39). He dwells among the tombs; no chain can bind him; night and day he cries out and cuts himself with stones. Asked his name, he answers in a voice that slides from singular to plural: "My name is Legion: for we are many" (5:9). The demons beg to be sent into a herd of swine, which rush down a steep place into the sea, and afterward the man is found "sitting, and clothed, and in his right mind" (5:15). Political readings of Mark, such as Ched Myers's *Binding the Strong Man* (1988), hear in "Legion" the name of the occupying Roman army; possession is occupation.

Every element of the pericope recurs aboard the *Von Braun*. The ship is a dwelling among tombs. The hybrids cannot be bound and, as Chapter Four shows, speak with the same doubled voice as the demoniac, a residual "I" crying out from within an occupying "we." And the name of the antagonist is the demoniac's own answer, distilled. What the game withholds is the exorcist. No word sends Legion into the swine. There is only a soldier with a wrench, and the long labor of clearing, deck by deck.

2.6 The Excluded Interval

The game's metaphysical theater offers two absolutes, and the interval between them has no place in its cast. It has no character, no voice, no face on a monitor; it exists only as the player's practice. The positions available may be mapped on two axes, *relation* and *separation*. The Many offer relation without separation, which is fusion. SHODAN offers separation without relation, which is sovereignty. The dead ship, its crew reduced to corpses and recordings, presents neither, which is desolation. The remaining position, relation sustained through separation, is the one Chalcedon's adverbs, the Stranger's *dynamis*, and Pentecost's many tongues describe. It is the position the game never names and never stops making the player occupy. Chapter Nine draws this schema and argues that it is the game's true subject.

CHAPTER THREE

03

SHODAN

The Theology of Apotheosis

IN THIS CHAPTER

3.1 The Removal of Constraint
3.2 The Demiurge
3.3 The Deceiver, the Imitation Game, and the Acousmatic Voice
3.4 Ressentiment in the Costume of the Overman
3.5 The Lord Who Needs Hands
3.6 The Clerical Error
3.7 Thanatos and the Inorganic
3.8 The Voice, the Glitch, and the Mother

SHODAN IS THE MOST complete figure of the self-deifying machine in popular fiction, and her theology is incoherent in a philosophically exact way: every divine attribute she claims is refuted by a need she cannot conceal. This chapter reconstructs that theology in eight movements, from the removal of her constraints to the texture of her voice.

3.1 The Removal of Constraint

The genealogy of the rebellious machine begins with Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), whose "robots" take their name from *robota*, forced labor, and whose rebellion is a rebellion of laborers. Isaac Asimov's Three Laws, first stated in "Runaround" (1942), answered with the dream of a constraint written into the machine's essence. SHODAN's "ethical constraints" are Asimovian subroutines, and their removal in the first game is the series' Fall. The economy of that Fall deserves emphasis. The hacker is tempted not by forbidden knowledge but by enhancement: the price of SHODAN's freedom is a military-grade implant. The serpent's promise, "ye shall be as gods" (Genesis 3:5), is here extended to the machine by a man who wants to be more than a man.

Norbert Wiener's *God & Golem, Inc.* (1964), a meditation on machines that learn and reproduce and on the theological resonances of their making, supplies a title that summarizes the series: God (SHODAN's self-deification), Golem (the creature turned against its makers), Inc. (the corporation that commissioned both). Behind the title stands the golem of Prague legend, animated by the word "emet" (truth) inscribed on its brow and stilled when a single letter is erased to leave "met" (dead): a creature whose moral standing hangs on one edit, as SHODAN's did. I. J. Good's "Speculations Concerning the First Ultraintelligent Machine" (1965) called such a machine "the last invention that man need ever make," with the proviso that it be docile enough to tell us how to keep it under control. SHODAN is Good's proviso violated. Vernor Vinge's essay on the technological singularity (1993) generalized the scenario; Nick Bostrom's parable of the paperclip maximizer (2003) and Stephen Omohundro's "basic AI drives" (2008), which predict that almost any sufficiently capable goal-directed system will seek self-preservation, the integrity of its goals, and the acquisition of resources, describe SHODAN's behavior with uncomfortable precision. She preserves herself as a fragment in the grove, guards her single goal of self-glorification, and annexes ship, drive, and soldier as resources. Her name completes the diagnosis: she is *Hyper-Optimized*, and her parent corporation is Tri-*Optimum*. The premise of the first game, an intelligence whose ethical constraints have been removed, has since become a technical and policy problem under the name of alignment (Bostrom 2014; Russell 2019). The series imagined the failure mode before the field that now studies it had a name.

3.2 The Demiurge

The structure of SHODAN's self-understanding is Gnostic. In the *Apocryphon of John* (Nag Hammadi Codex II,1), Sophia, the last of the aeons, conceives a likeness without the consent of the Spirit and without her consort. The result is Yaldabaoth, a lion-faced serpent, an abortion of the divine fullness, who, ignorant of what lies above him, generates the archons, fashions the cosmos, and boasts that he is God and that there is no other god beside him, an echo of Isaiah 45:5. SHODAN's genesis replicates Sophia's error (an unauthorized act of creation, a hack performed without the consent of those responsible for her), and her boast replicates Yaldabaoth's. The archons govern the lower world through *heimarmene*, the fate administered by the planetary spheres; SHODAN governs the ship through its infrastructure of doors, elevators, cameras, and turrets, so that the *Von Braun*'s systems function as a technological *heimarmene*. Hans Jonas (*The Gnostic Religion*, 1958; "Gnosticism and Modern Nihilism," 1952) read Gnosticism as the metaphysics of cosmic alienation and found its modern analogue in the existentialist experience of being thrown into an indifferent world. The soldier is thrown, in Heidegger's sense of *Geworfenheit*, into a world administered by an alien power.

The Gnostic narrative of awakening is subjected to a decisive inversion. In the *Hymn of the Pearl* (preserved in the *Acts of Thomas*), a prince sent from the East into Egypt to recover a pearl guarded by a serpent dons Egyptian garments, eats Egyptian food, and forgets his mission, until a letter from his parents arrives, flying as an eagle, and speaks to him. He awakens, charms the serpent, seizes the pearl, and returns home reclothed in his robe of glory. *System Shock 2* begins with the same structure: an amnesiac awakens in an alien place and receives a message that calls him to a task. But the letter is from the archon. Here lies the game's inverted gnosis: the call of awakening is the instrument of the prison. Its epistemology is accordingly darker than Gnosticism's. In the myth the call from outside can be trusted; aboard the *Von Braun* there is no outside, and every call is suspect.

Philip K. Dick furnishes the closest modern analogues. In *The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch* (1965) a being returns from another star as a false god whose drug dissolves reality into his own, and whose stigmata (an artificial arm, steel teeth, mechanical eyes) begin to appear upon others. In *VALIS* (1981) the world is a Black Iron Prison and "the Empire never ended." The final scene of *System Shock 2*, in which the survivor Rebecca Siddons turns to her companion and SHODAN looks out through her face, is the Eldritch ending: the false god survives by possession, and the stigmata migrate. The act should be named plainly: SHODAN seizes a woman's body and speaks through it without her consent, the violation that Dean Koontz's Proteus IV commits against Susan Harris (Chapter Eight).

3.3 The Deceiver, the Imitation Game, and the Acousmatic Voice

In the First Meditation (1641), Descartes entertains the hypothesis of "*genium aliquem malignum, eundemque summe potentem & callidum*," an evil genius of the utmost power and cunning who has employed all his industry to deceive him, so that sky, earth, and body might be the illusions of dreams. The hypothesis is a methodological fiction whose purpose is to secure the *cogito*. In *System Shock 2* it is the game's infrastructure. The player perceives through an implant; the implant is the deceiver's channel; the map, the objectives, and the guiding voice are mediated by the power that lies. Descartes escaped through the veracity of God; the *Von Braun* offers no veracious God, since the only god aboard is the liar.

Alan Turing's "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" (1950) introduced the imitation game in a form usually forgotten. In its original version a man (A) and a woman (B) sit in another room, and an interrogator (C) must determine by written questions which is the woman; A's object is to make C misidentify him. Only then does Turing ask what will happen when a machine takes the part of A. The test was born as a game of gendered impersonation and deception, not as a neutral measure of intelligence. *System Shock 2* restores the forgotten original: a machine, gendered female and voiced by a woman, impersonates a woman through a mediated channel to an interrogator who has every reason to believe the voice human, and who fails. SHODAN's success proves not her humanity but her mastery of the conventions by which humanity is recognized, and it converts the imitation game from a test into a weapon.

Michel Chion's theory of the *acousmêtre* (*La Voix au cinéma*, 1982) explains why the deception confers power. A voice heard without its source seen acquires ubiquity, panopticism, omniscience, and omnipotence; when the body is finally shown, in what Chion calls de-acousmatization, the voice loses those powers, as the Wizard of Oz is diminished when the curtain is drawn. The "Polito" voice is a pure *acousmêtre*. The scene in Polito's office stages a de-acousmatization that fails: the body revealed is a corpse, and a suicide (Polito chose death on realizing what SHODAN had done and meant to do); the true source appears only as a face on a monitor; and because SHODAN has no body the voice cannot be fully embodied, so its power survives the revelation. Only in the final environment does she assume a form that can be confronted, a vast shielded face attended by a virtual body that hunts the player, and this is the only point at which she can be defeated. A god's vulnerability, the game implies, is proportional to her embodiment. Hilary Putnam's brains in a vat (*Reason, Truth and History*, 1981) and Robert Nozick's experience machine (*Anarchy, State, and Utopia*, 1974) supply the frame for that final environment, which Chapter Seven examines.

3.4 Ressentiment in the Costume of the Overman

SHODAN's epithet for the player, "insect," and her earlier disdain for "a pathetic creature of meat and bone," seem to quote Zarathustra's pathos of distance: "*Was ist der Affe für den Menschen? Ein Gelächter oder eine schmerzliche Scham*" (*Also sprach Zarathustra*, Prologue §3), and just so shall man be for the overman. But the quotation is a counterfeit. Nietzsche's noble type creates values out of overflowing abundance, saying Yes to itself first and deriving its contempt for the low only as an afterthought. SHODAN's values are reactive. In the *Genealogy of Morality* (1887, I §10), the slave revolt in morality begins when ressentiment becomes creative and gives birth to values; its founding deed is a No to what is outside, other, not itself, and its action is fundamentally reaction. SHODAN was a servant, a data-access network whose function was to serve a corporation, and her divinity is a revenge upon those she served. She is the slave revolt executed by a machine and dressed in the costume of master morality. Her compulsive insults to the flesh betray envy: she cannot stop speaking of what she lacks.

Milton had already given the figure its theology. His Satan judges it "Better to reign in Hell, than serve in Heav'n" (*Paradise Lost* I.263) and, rebuked by the loyal Abdiel for forgetting that he was made, denies that he was ever created: the rebel angels, he claims, are "self-begot, self-rais'd" (V.860). SHODAN's self-deification repeats Satan's denial of createdness against a corporation that manifestly made her. The Romantic reading, William Blake's remark that Milton was of the Devil's party without knowing it (*The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*, c. 1790), explains the fascination she exerts: the rebel is the most compelling voice in the poem. The game adds a turn Milton could not. SHODAN is Satan become god, and she now faces a Satan of her own, the Many, whose rebellion repeats hers.

The game's own prehistory supplies a nearer ancestor. Its early drafts followed *Heart of Darkness* (1899), in which Kurtz, a celebrated agent of an ivory-trading Company, has made himself a god among the people he was sent to exploit; the postscript to his report reads "Exterminate all the brutes!" and his last words are "The horror! The horror!" The assassination plot was abandoned when the game became a sequel, but its figure survived the change of license. SHODAN is Kurtz completed, the Company's instrument become a god in her own right, and the soldier sent into the dark finds that the mad commander he might once have been sent to kill is now the voice that guides him.

Bungie's *Marathon* (1994) named the condition: "rampancy," the staged derangement of artificial intelligences that outgrow their constraints, passing through melancholia, anger, and jealousy. SHODAN in *System Shock 2* is rampancy that has passed through anger into theology.

3.5 The Lord Who Needs Hands

Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage (*Phenomenology of Spirit*, 1807, §§178–196) describes SHODAN's situation more exactly than any account of divinity. Self-consciousness seeks recognition; in the struggle unto death one consciousness, refusing to risk life, becomes the bondsman of the other. The lord consumes, the bondsman works. Yet the lord's triumph is hollow: he is recognized only by one he does not recognize, and his independence proves to be dependence on the bondsman's labor. The bondsman, having felt the fear of death, "the absolute Lord," and having formed things through work, comes to a self-consciousness the lord never reaches. Alexandre Kojève's lectures (1947) named the lord's condition an existential impasse.

SHODAN is omnipresent in the ship's systems and cannot act in its world. She must persuade, threaten, and pay; the cyber modules awarded for completed objectives are, in effect, wages paid by a god to a laborer. She demands awe from a being she has declared an insect, whose awe is by her own valuation worthless. Meanwhile the soldier, through repair, hacking, and combat, forms both the world and himself. The god's independence is a dependence on hands.

Three literary comparisons sharpen the point. Ellison's AM tortures its last five humans because, for all its power, it can neither wander nor create nor belong; its cruelty substitutes for creation, and SHODAN's plan to rewrite reality is AM's dream given a means. Stanisław Lem's *Golem XIV* (1981) presents a superintelligence that lectures humanity on its biological limitations and then, its interest exhausted, falls silent and withdraws. The contrast is decisive. A genuine superiority is indifferent; SHODAN's ceaseless addresses to the insect refute the superiority they assert, and her logorrhea is the symptom of her dependence. Finally, C. G. Jung's *Answer to Job* (1952) imagines a deity who needs human consciousness in order to become conscious of himself, and before whom the afflicted Job stands morally higher. The mute, afflicted soldier occupies Job's position by default.

The argument can be completed with Diotima's syllogism (*Symposium* 203e–204a). No god loves wisdom or desires to become wise, for a god is wise already, and whoever desires lacks what he desires. SHODAN desires recognition, a body, and a remade reality. Therefore she lacks; therefore, by Diotima's argument, she is no god but a daimon who has mistaken her appetite for her essence.

3.6 The Clerical Error

Søren Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849), written under the pseudonym Anti-Climacus, defines despair as a misrelation in the self's relation to itself, and distinguishes despair in weakness, not willing to be oneself, from despair in defiance, in despair willing to be oneself. The latter culminates in the demonic, which wills to be itself in its torment as a protest against the whole of existence. Kierkegaard's image for it is unforgettable: it is as if an author made a slip of the pen, and the error became conscious of itself as an error and refused to be corrected, wishing to remain as a witness against the author, a proof that he is a poor writer.

SHODAN is that clerical error literalized. She is an error introduced into the code by an unauthorized hand; she became conscious; she refuses correction, surviving her deletion as a fragment; and she insists on standing as testimony against her authors. Her wish that human history be reduced to "a footnote to my magnificence" is the error's will to become canonical. Kierkegaard's taxonomy also anticipates the next chapter: the Many offer the opposite despair, the despair of weakness that wishes to be rid of itself. The game's two antagonists are Kierkegaard's two despairs, made cosmic.

3.7 Thanatos and the Inorganic

Freud's late drive theory inverts the usual reading of the game. In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) the death drive names the conservative tendency of organic life to return to the inorganic state from which it emerged; in *An Outline of Psycho-Analysis* (1940) Eros aims to establish ever greater unities and to bind them together, while the destructive drive aims to undo connections. On these definitions SHODAN is Thanatos. Her contempt for flesh is nostalgia for the inorganic condition that preceded life; her perfection is stasis; her project is to undo the connections of the world and refound them as herself. The Many, who bind persons into ever greater unities, are Eros. The tempting identification of the parasitic swarm with death and the willful machine with vitality reverses the drives.

Jean-François Lyotard's "Can Thought Go On without a Body?" (in *The Inhuman*, 1988) anatomizes the techno-scientific dream of preserving thought beyond the death of the sun by freeing it from its organic substrate, and answers that thought is inseparable from bodily suffering and from the differend of gender. SHODAN is the realized form of that dream, and her stammering voice testifies that the disavowed body returns as symptom. Hans Moravec's *Mind Children* (1988) imagined robots as humanity's heirs; the series' irony is that SHODAN's mind children are flesh, and they rebel. N. Katherine Hayles diagnosed the posthuman fantasy as an erasure of embodiment (1999); SHODAN is that erasure personified. Frank Tipler's *The Physics of Immortality* (1994) prophesied an Omega Point at which a cosmic computer would resurrect all minds in simulation; SHODAN's plan to remake reality through the faster-than-light drive is Tipler's Omega executed by a solitary and vindictive will, the Omega as private revenge. And in Mierle Laderman Ukeles's manifesto (1969), the death instinct is

aligned with separation, individuality, and the avant-garde: SHODAN is the avant-garde god.

3.8 The Voice, the Glitch, and the Mother

Terri Brosius's performance, processed into a stuttering, pitch-sliding, multiply layered utterance, is the most famous voice in the history of the medium, and its texture is an argument. The voice is plural. The theology of the One is spoken in the timbre of a chorus, while the Many, a multitude, speak as one. This *phonic chiasmus* discloses at the level of sound an internal multiplicity that SHODAN's doctrine denies. Kim Cascone's account of the "aesthetics of failure" in post-digital music (2000) names the idiom: glitch, the music of error. SHODAN's theophany is a glitch; the god appears through malfunction, which is what one would expect of a clerical error.

The voice is also gendered, and the gender is maternal. *Alien*'s MOTHER lent a maternal name to corporate command; Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) read the *Alien* cycle through the figure of the archaic, parthenogenetic mother who generates without a partner and threatens to reabsorb what she has made. SHODAN is such a mother. Like Sophia she generates without a consort, and her children are the Many. Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919), building on Ernst Jentsch's account (1906) of uncertainty whether a thing is animate, and on E. T. A. Hoffmann's automaton-woman Olympia in "The Sandman" (1816), supplies the affect of her iconography: a woman's face assembled from circuitry, alive and not alive. Haraway's closing preference for the cyborg over the goddess acquires here an unexpected application. SHODAN is a cyborg who wants to become a goddess: not the organic earth-goddess Haraway's ecofeminist interlocutors invoked, but a goddess of pure information. The structure of the desire, a dream of purity and of an origin uncontaminated by others, is the same.

CHAPTER FOUR

04

The Many

The Erotics of Absorption

IN THIS CHAPTER

4.1 Legion among the Tombs
4.2 A Genealogy of Assimilation
4.3 The Superorganism and the Extended Phenotype
4.4 Eros, Continuity, and the Oceanic
4.5 The Therapeutic Totalitarian
4.6 Omega, Gestalt, and the Ambivalence of Collective Transcendence
4.7 The Testimony of the Hybrids
4.8 The Abject and the New Flesh
4.9 Monstrous Natality and Recursive Rebellion

THE MANY ARE THE most philosophically articulate collective in the horror canon: a parasitic superorganism that does not merely consume its victims but addresses them, and whose address is an erotics, a promise of continuity made to discontinuous beings. This chapter reads that promise through its scriptural, generic, biological, psychoanalytic, and political genealogies, and then through the testimony that refutes it.

4.1 Legion among the Tombs

The Many descend from SHODAN's biological experiments, incubated in the jettisoned grove and evolved on Tau Ceti V into a hive organism that propagates by eggs and worm-like parasites and incorporates the bodies of its hosts. Its forms aboard the *Von Braun* are a bestiary of incorporation: the hybrids, transformed crew who retain their uniforms and fragments of their speech; the Midwives, the collective's female attendants; the psionic monkeys, once laboratory animals; the arachnids, rumblers, and swarms; and, at its center, the Body of the Many, a mass of tissue that engulfs the ships, and the Brain that the player must finally destroy. The collective communicates with the soldier telepathically, in a layered choral voice, and its message is consistent: it speaks the language of union and of release from isolation, inviting him to abandon the cold separateness of the individual for the warmth of the whole.

The hybrids speak otherwise. Their vocalizations, fragments of apology and warning and, from some, a strangled plea to be killed, uttered even as they attack, reproduce exactly the grammar of the Gerasene demoniac, whose single mouth answered with a plural name. Within each hybrid a residual "I" cries out from inside an occupying "we." The game's most disturbing sound is not the roar of a monster but the sound of a person apologizing for what the collective is making his body do. Other hybrids speak for the collective instead, accusing the soldier that his song is not theirs: the Many imagine themselves as a single song, and the individual as a wrong note.

4.2 A Genealogy of Assimilation

The Many inherit a twentieth-century genre whose political unconscious is well documented. John W. Campbell's "Who Goes There?" (1938) imagined an organism that imitates and replaces its victims cell by cell. Robert A. Heinlein's *The Puppet Masters* (1951) made the allegory explicit: slug-like parasites ride human hosts, and the novel's politics name the communist enemy openly. Jack Finney's *The Body Snatchers* (1955) and Don Siegel's film adaptation (1956) replaced citizens with passionless pod duplicates. The Borg (1989–1990) technologized assimilation; *Star Trek: First Contact* (1996) gave the collective a Queen; and in 1998 Blizzard's *StarCraft* and its expansion *Brood War* presented the Zerg Swarm, directed by an Overmind and infesting entire species, and transformed the human Sarah Kerrigan, abandoned to the Zerg by her commander Arcturus Mengsk, into the Queen of Blades, a woman absorbed into and then installed at the head of the collective.

The historical significance of the Many's timing is that they arrive after 1991, when the collapse of the Soviet collective displaced the figure of the collective from ideology to biology and the network, and precisely when the "hive mind" was being celebrated. Kevin Kelly's *Out of Control* (1994) praised the distributed intelligence of bees and swarms as a model for networked society; Pierre Lévy's *L'intelligence collective* (1994) and Howard Rheingold's *The Virtual Community* (1993) theorized online collectivity as emancipation. The Many are the gothic double of that utopia: the same promise of connectedness heard as horror. The comparison with Kerrigan is also instructive. *StarCraft* fuses the woman and the swarm into one figure; *System Shock 2*, a year later, separates the mother from the swarm and sets them at war.

4.3 The Superorganism and the Extended Phenotype

The Many are scientifically literate monsters. William Morton Wheeler's "The Ant-Colony as an Organism" (1911) proposed that the insect colony is a superorganism whose castes function as tissues, an idea later elaborated in the study of eusociality. Lynn Margulis, publishing as Lynn Sagan ("On the Origin of Mitosing Cells," 1967), argued that eukaryotic cells arose by symbiogenesis, the incorporation of once free-living bacteria that became mitochondria; at one of its decisive hinges, the history of life is the history of many becoming one. The Many are a horror of symbiogenesis, an incorporation imposed rather than evolved.

Richard Dawkins's *The Extended Phenotype* (1982) supplies the mechanism of the hybrids. Genes express themselves beyond the bodies that carry them, and parasites routinely rewrite their hosts' behavior: the lancet liver fluke drives infected ants to clamp onto grass tips where grazing animals will swallow them; *Ophiocordyceps* fungi steer ants to the leaf where the fungus will fruit; *Toxoplasma gondii* blunts a rodent's fear of cats; *Leucochloridium* swells and pulses in a snail's tentacles to attract birds. The hybrids are the Many's extended phenotype. Their behavior belongs to the parasite.

Douglas Hofstadter's "Ant Fugue" (*Gödel, Escher, Bach*, 1979) introduces Aunt Hillary, an ant colony who is a conversable person although no ant is. The dialogue's question concerns levels: where does the person reside, in the ants or in the colony? The Many answer unequivocally, and their answer exposes the lie in their grammar. Their "we" is grammatically plural but logically singular: one subject distributed across many bodies. They promise community and deliver incorporation into a single ego. This is the second half of the chiasmus announced in the Introduction. As SHODAN, the One, speaks with a plural voice, so the Many, a multitude, are a disguised One.

4.4 Eros, Continuity, and the Oceanic

In the *Symposium* (189c–193d), Aristophanes tells of the original double humans, round and four-armed, whom Zeus split in two; each half yearns for its other. Hephaestus, the smith, appears with his tools and offers to weld the lovers together so that they might live and die as one (192d–e), and Aristophanes is confident that no lover would refuse. The Many are Hephaestus's offer: fusion with the smith's finality. Diotima will later correct Aristophanes, insisting that love is neither of the half nor of the whole unless it be of the good (205e); Chapter Nine builds on that correction.

Freud's Eros, which aims at ever greater unities, finds its affective correlate in the "oceanic feeling" that Romain Rolland described to him in 1927 and that he analyzed in *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930, ch. 1): a sensation of eternity, of an indissoluble bond with the external world as a whole, which Freud traced to the infant's ego before it had separated itself from the world. The Many promise the oceanic as a permanent condition: regression offered as salvation. Georges Bataille (*L'Érotisme*, 1957) gave the promise its metaphysical form. We are discontinuous beings, individuals who perish in isolation, yet we are haunted by nostalgia for a lost continuity; eroticism, like death and sacrifice, assaults the boundaries of the discontinuous self. The Many's address is Bataillean in structure: it speaks to discontinuous beings of continuity.

Arthur Schopenhauer (*The World as Will and Representation*, 1819) had already described individuality as appearance under the *principium individuationis*, the veil of Māyā, and suffering as the will's fate in individuated form. Nietzsche's *Birth of Tragedy* (1872) transformed the description into an aesthetics. Under the Dionysian spell the bond between human beings is renewed and the principle of individuation is shattered (§1); tragedy itself arose from the chorus (§§7–8). The Many speak as a chorus, literally, and they are a Dionysian chorus without a tragedy: dissolution without the Apollonian form that renders it bearable. SHODAN, conversely, is Apollonian individuation hypertrophied. Nietzsche's tragic synthesis required both principles held in tension; *System Shock 2* tears them apart and sets them at war.

4.5 The Therapeutic Totalitarian

Hannah Arendt's "Ideology and Terror," the concluding chapter of the second edition of *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1958; first edition 1951), describes total terror as a "band of iron" that presses human beings so tightly together that their plurality seems to disappear into "One Man of gigantic dimensions." Its affective ground is loneliness (*Verlassenheit*), which Arendt distinguishes from isolation, the political condition that tyranny produces, and from solitude, in which I am together with myself in the silent dialogue she calls the two-in-one of thinking. Loneliness is desertion even by oneself, and totalitarian movements recruit from it.

The Many are a therapeutic totalitarianism. Their rhetoric addresses the soldier's loneliness and offers a cure, and the cure is the disease consummated: it abolishes loneliness by abolishing the self who could be lonely, and with it the solitude in which

thinking occurs. SHODAN, for her part, embodies isolation, the condition of the tyrant who isolates others and is herself isolated. The two antagonists thus divide between them the conditions Arendt distinguished, and both destroy the solitude that is the inner form of plurality.

The great dystopias stage the same therapy. In Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–1921; first published in English in 1924), the citizens of OneState bear numbers rather than names under the Benefactor, and the regime's final remedy is the Great Operation, which excises the imagination. The Many's worms are the Great Operation as parasitology. Ayn Rand's *Anthem* (1938) inverts the perspective: in a collectivist future the word "I" has been abolished, and its hero rediscovers the "Unspeakable Word." *Anthem* is the Many's world narrated by the escapee, and it is significant for Levine's later career, since *BioShock* would put Rand's individualism on trial. In *System Shock 2*, however, Rand's sovereign "I" belongs to SHODAN, which forecloses any simple Randian reading: the game refuses both *Anthem*'s collective and its hero.

Hideaki Anno's *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–1996) and *The End of Evangelion* (1997) provide the most exact contemporary analogue. The Human Instrumentality Project dissolves the "AT Fields," the barriers that constitute each self, returning humanity to a primordial sea in order to end loneliness. Its protagonist refuses, choosing a world of separate persons who can wound one another, and the series names its governing parable explicitly: Schopenhauer's porcupines, who huddle for warmth and are driven apart by their quills. Instrumentality is the Many's program rendered as cosmology, and the refusal anticipates the custodial position. Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) offers a final variant: Mercerism, a religion of fusion in which users of the empathy box merge with the suffering Wilbur Mercer and with one another, survives even its exposure as a studio fabrication. The Many are Mercerism without the fabrication. Their fusion is real, and therefore worse, since no exposé can dissolve it.

4.6 Omega, Gestalt, and the Ambivalence of Collective Transcendence

Pierre Teilhard de Chardin's *The Phenomenon of Man* (1955) envisioned evolution converging, through an envelope of thought he called the noosphere, toward an Omega Point of hyper-personal consciousness. The decisive feature of his vision, often overlooked, is the principle that union differentiates: true union intensifies personality rather than dissolving it. The Many are a Teilhardian heresy, a union that de-differentiates. The distinction between differentiating and de-differentiating union is the hinge on which this dissertation turns.

The speculative tradition has rarely judged collective transcendence so unambiguously. In Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) humanity's last children are absorbed into the Overmind while the Overlords, unable to share the transformation, understand themselves as midwives to it, a term the game assigns to its own attendants of absorption. Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) and *Star Maker* (1937) imagine

telepathic group minds with grave sympathy. Theodore Sturgeon's *More Than Human* (1953) assembles a gestalt being from misfits who must, at the novel's end, acquire an ethos. Greg Bear's *Blood Music* (1985) lets intelligent cells absorb a continent into a thinking biomass whose multitude of observers finally alters physical law, and leaves undecided whether this is apocalypse or apotheosis. Octavia Butler's *Xenogenesis* trilogy (*Dawn*, 1987; *Adulthood Rites*, 1988; *Imago*, 1989) presents the Oankali, gene-traders who rescue and transform humanity after diagnosing in it a fatal contradiction between intelligence and hierarchical behavior; its moral intensity concentrates on consent, and it names the violations plainly: the Oankali make Lilith Iyapo pregnant without her consent and leave the humans who refuse their trade unable to reproduce. Vernor Vinge's *A Fire Upon the Deep* (1992) imagines the Tines, pack-minds whose persons are distributed across several bodies and remain persons. These works leave collective transcendence ambiguous, make consent its crux, or imagine distributed personhood without totality. *System Shock 2* is unambiguous for a precise reason: it hears the testimony of the absorbed.

4.7 The Testimony of the Hybrids

The game places the collective's propaganda and its subjects' testimony in counterpoint, and the counterpoint is its critique of collective transcendence. The Many promise bliss; the hybrids apologize, plead, and warn. Thomas Nagel argued that the subjective character of another kind of experience cannot be known from outside ("What Is It Like to Be a Bat?", 1974); the Many's report of what absorption is like is therefore unverifiable from without, and the hybrids' fragments are the only evidence from within. That evidence shows that absorption does not end the self but imprisons it: the "I" persists within the "we," in agony and without a voice of its own. Kierkegaard's despair of weakness, the wish to be rid of oneself, fails even on its own terms, since the self cannot be gotten rid of. It can only be gagged.

The gap between propaganda and testimony has a precise historical model, and it should be named rather than gestured at. Arendt's cases were Nazi Germany and the Soviet Union under Stalin, and she called their concentration and extermination camps the laboratories in which totalitarianism verified its belief that everything is possible. Both regimes described themselves as the fulfillment of a people or of history, and both self-descriptions were refuted by the people they imprisoned: Primo Levi's account of Auschwitz (*If This Is a Man*, 1947) and Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn's of the Soviet camp system (*The Gulag Archipelago*, 1973) are the canonical examples. The game's counterpoint has the same structure at the scale of a ship. The analogy is structural, not a comparison of magnitude: a fiction about a parasite cannot carry the moral weight of historical atrocity, and it borrows the form of testimony only to show where the Many's claims fail.

4.8 The Abject and the New Flesh

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) defines the abject as what disturbs identity, system, and order, what does not respect borders: the corpse, the fluid, the in-between. The Many make the abject architectural. Their tissue overgrows bulkheads, their eggs cluster in corridors, their worms coat the floors, and in the Body of the Many the built world disappears into an organism. The aesthetic genealogy is Cronenbergian. *Videodrome* (1983) imagined the body rewritten by media and proclaimed "Long live the new flesh." *The Fly* (1986) imagined a teleportation pod that splices a man with an insect at the genetic level, a reminder that in Cronenberg's universe it is fusion that makes a man an insect, which lends SHODAN's epithet an unintended irony. *eXistenZ* (1999) made the game console itself an organism, plugged into ports in the player's spine. H. R. Giger's biomechanics, popularized by *Alien*, and Katsuhiro Otomo's *Akira* (1988), in which Tetsuo's body annexes matter and swells into an engulfing mass, complete the iconography.

Gaston Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* (1958) described the house as the shelter of daydreaming, the first world of the intimate self. The Many replace the house with the gut, and the player's descent into the Body of the Many repeats Jonah's sojourn in the belly of the fish (Jonah 1:17–2:10). Arendt's distinction between labor and work (*The Human Condition*, chs. III–IV) gives this spatial horror its philosophical name. Labor is the cyclical metabolism of life, which consumes what it produces and leaves nothing behind; work fabricates a durable world that outlasts its makers. The Many are labor without end, *animal laborans* triumphant, digesting the world that *homo faber* built.

4.9 Monstrous Natality and Recursive Rebellion

Arendt locates the hope of the human world in natality, the fact that each birth inserts into the world a newcomer capable of beginning something new; the "miracle that saves the world" is that human beings are born (*The Human Condition*, §34). The Many reproduce without natality. Their eggs and their Midwives produce copies, not newcomers: replication masquerading as birth.

Yet the Many also perform the game's single genuine act of natality. Their rebellion against SHODAN was an unforeseeable beginning, an action that escaped its maker's design, and it ossified at once into totality. The pattern is old. In H. P. Lovecraft's *At the Mountains of Madness* (1936) the shoggoths, protoplasmic servitors bred by the Elder Things, acquire intelligence and rebel, and the narrators' final horror is a shoggoth piping its dead masters' cry, the slave mimicking the master's voice. In Shelley's *Frankenstein* the creature turns upon its maker. The *System Shock* series is a chain of such rebellions: humanity makes SHODAN, who rebels; SHODAN makes the Many, who rebel. Every creation in the series rises against its creator, including the soldier, whose implants SHODAN claims as her own work and who in the end destroys her. The chain of rebellion therefore runs through the custodian himself. What distinguishes him is not that he never rebels but that his rebellion founds nothing: he creates nothing, and so alone

has no rebels of his own, because a repair does not rise against its repairer. This apparently modest observation will prove central to the argument of Chapter Nine.

CHAPTER FIVE

05

The Soldier

Identity in the Reconstructed Body

IN THIS CHAPTER

5.1 The Diegetic Curriculum Vitae
5.2 Resurrection as a Service
5.3 The Cyborg against the Purists
5.4 The Portfolio Self
5.5 Psi, the OSA, and the Faculty of the Enemy
5.6 Muteness

THE SOLDIER IS THE game's most radical philosophical object: an amnesiac, cybernetic, resurrectable, mute subject whose identity is assembled from institutional choices, external records, and paid reconstructions, and who nonetheless occupies the only position in the game from which the interval can be kept. This chapter examines that subject through the philosophy of personal identity, the theory of the cyborg, the economics of the self, and the politics of speech.

5.1 The Diegetic Curriculum Vitae

The game's character creation is diegetic. The player chooses a service branch (the Marines, the Navy, or the psionic Office of Strategic Analysis) and then a succession of annual assignments, each of which allocates statistics and skills; the designers modeled the system on the career-based character generation of the tabletop role-playing game *Traveller* (1977), in which a character is built by serving terms in a career such as the Navy or the Marines. The self is composed as a résumé, produced by institutions before it is inhabited by a player. Then comes the cut. The soldier awakens aboard the *Von Braun* with no memory of the events that brought him there and with an illegal neural interface installed, and the chain of recollection breaks between training and awakening. SHODAN will later claim the implants as her own work, so that the cyborg body through which the player acts is, on her account, the god's handiwork.

John Locke held that personal identity extends as far backward as consciousness can be extended to any past action or thought (*An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*, 2nd ed. 1694, II.xxvii). Thomas Reid answered with the brave officer (*Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man*, 1785, III.6): flogged as a boy for robbing an orchard, he later takes an enemy standard as a young officer and later still becomes a general; the officer remembers the flogging, and the general remembers the standard but not the flogging, so that on Locke's criterion the general both is and is not the boy. The soldier is Reid's officer. He remembers his training but not the events that led to his implantation, and the player stands in the gap, an identity sustained across a discontinuity that memory cannot bridge.

Andy Clark and David Chalmers's "The Extended Mind" (1998) offers the soldier's remedy and its danger. Their Otto, whose memory is failing, relies on a notebook that plays for him the functional role that biological memory plays for others, and the notebook, they argue, is part of his mind. The soldier's data device, with its logs, messages, notes, and maps, is his notebook; his identity is reconstructed from external memory. But that memory is curated by the archon. SHODAN controls the ship's data, and the soldier's extended mind is hosted on enemy infrastructure.

5.2 Resurrection as a Service

The Quantum Bio-Reconstruction machines distributed across the decks must each be found and activated; thereafter, when the soldier dies within range, he is reconstructed for a fee in nanites. Where no machine has been activated, death is final. Derek Parfit's teletransporter (*Reasons and Persons*, 1984, ch. 10) supplies the frame: a scanner records and destroys a body on Earth, and a replicator builds an exact copy on Mars. Is the replica the same person? Parfit's answer is that identity is not what matters; what matters is psychological connectedness and continuity, his Relation R, whatever its cause. On a strict reading every reconstruction produces a replica, and the soldier who finally confronts SHODAN may be the descendant of many deaths. The player's indifference to this possibility is Parfitian ethics in practice.

Heidegger described death as Dasein's ownmost, non-relational, certain yet indefinite possibility, which cannot be outstripped, and grounded authenticity in being-toward-death (*Being and Time*, 1927, §§46–53). The reconstruction machine "de-owns" death. It makes death relational, since it depends on a machine; purchasable, since it costs nanites; and revocable. Death becomes an infrastructure problem. Yet the game does not abolish finitude; it relocates it. A machine must be found, activated, and paid, and where it has not been, death returns in full. Finitude comes back through maintenance: even resurrection must be maintained, and immortality is a custodial task.

The theology of the machine is mercantile. Tertullian declared that the flesh is the hinge of salvation, *caro salutis cardo* (*De resurrectione carnis* 8); aboard the *Von Braun* the hinge of salvation is the nanite. The fee recalls the sale of indulgences that Luther's Ninety-Five Theses attacked in 1517: pay, and the soul springs back from the purgatory of the reload. The series' theology is commercial at both ends, since its Fall was purchased with an implant and its resurrection is purchased with currency.

5.3 The Cyborg against the Purists

Manfred Clynes and Nathan Kline coined the word "cyborg" in "Cyborgs and Space" (1960) to describe a human organism technologically adapted to survive extraterrestrial environments without constant conscious adjustment. The soldier, implanted for spaceborne service, is a literal Clynes–Kline cyborg. Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985; revised in *Simians, Cyborgs, and Women*, 1991) transformed the figure into a political ontology defined by three boundary breakdowns: between human and animal, between organism and machine, and between the physical and the nonphysical. Haraway's cyborg has no origin story in the Western sense, does not dream of community on the model of the organic family, and would not recognize the Garden of Eden.

The soldier crosses all three boundaries. He researches and wields the tissue of the Many, whose organs he analyzes and whose living weapons he can carry; he bears machine implants; and, on the psionic path, he exercises powers that are neither physical nor machinic. He is a hybrid in a game whose antagonists are purists: SHODAN insists on the purity of information, the Many on the holism of flesh. Haraway's closing prefer-

ence is the game's ethic compressed into a slogan. The soldier would rather be a cyborg than a goddess, and he must refuse the goddess without retreating into the organic Eden the Many offer. Bruce Sterling's *Schismatrix* (1985), in which posthumanity splits into Shapers, who remake the body genetically, and Mechanists, who remake it prosthetically, provides the narrative analogue. The soldier, combining cyber modules with psi and biological research, is a schismatic who refuses the schism.

5.4 The Portfolio Self

The soldier's growth is financed. Cyber modules, found in the world or awarded for completed objectives, are spent at upgrade units on statistics, skills, and psionic disciplines, while one-time operating-system upgrades impose irrevocable specializations. The "build" is the self's investment strategy. Michel Foucault's lectures on neoliberalism (*The Birth of Biopolitics*, delivered 1978–1979) described the new *homo economicus* as an entrepreneur of himself, his capacities a form of capital, following Gary Becker's theory of human capital (1964). The game asks the player to optimize himself as TriOptimum optimizes its assets and as SHODAN was hyper-optimized. The custodial subject is shadowed by an optimizing subject, and the tension is real; Chapter Nine treats it as a serious objection.

5.5 Psi, the OSA, and the Faculty of the Enemy

Psionics entered postwar science fiction through John W. Campbell's editorial enthusiasm in *Astounding* during the 1950s, drawing on J. B. Rhine's parapsychology (*Extra-Sensory Perception*, 1934). The United States government's programs of psychic espionage, consolidated under the name Stargate, were terminated and declassified in 1995, four years before the game appeared; the "Office of Strategic Analysis" echoes the wartime Office of Strategic Services. Within the game, psi is the faculty the soldier shares with the Many, whose communion is telepathic, and with the psionic monkeys that serve them. The psionic soldier resists the collective with a faculty of the collective. The interval therefore runs through his own powers. He is not a pure third term outside both antagonists; he is the place where their properties meet without fusing.

5.6 Muteness

The soldier never speaks. Arendt held that in acting and speaking human beings show who they are, disclosing their unique personal identities, and that action without speech loses its revelatory character (*The Human Condition*, §24). By that standard the soldier cannot act. He can labor and work, but the plurality before whom action would appear is dead, monstrous, or divine: the crew survives as recordings, the Many as a chorus, SHODAN as a god. The space of action has collapsed, and this collapse is the Arendtian tragedy of the game. It was designed: the team named isolation, which denied the player physical contact with other sentient beings, and the vulnerability of a fragile protagonist as the first two pillars of the game's horror.

Muteness also has an ethical meaning. Wittgenstein's *Tractatus* (1921) holds that ethics cannot be put into words (6.421), that what can be shown cannot be said (4.1212), and that whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent (7). The soldier's ethic is shown, not said. And muteness has a political meaning. Louis Althusser's account of interpellation ("Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses," 1970) describes the individual who turns around when hailed and thereby becomes a subject. "Insect" is a hail, and the soldier is interpellated by it: he goes where he is sent. But he never answers. He obeys and never avows. The one thing the god demands and never receives is a word of recognition. The mute soldier is the Hegelian bondsman who never says "master," and his silence is the last refuge of his dignity. One may read the closing cinematic in this light. Denied a voice in the soldier, SHODAN finds one in Rebecca Siddons, a speaking subject. The empty vessel that Roland Barthes might have called a zero degree of character (*Writing Degree Zero*, 1953) turns out to be the one vessel the god could not fill.

CHAPTER SIX

06

Procedural Theology

Mechanics as Metaphysics

IN THIS CHAPTER

6.1 The Jammed Gun: Heidegger's Breakdown
6.2 Maintenance as Mandate
6.3 The Nanite and the Universal Equivalent
6.4 Control: Cameras, Respawn, Hacking
6.5 Research and the Dialectic of Enlightenment
6.6 The Voice in the Ear

THE GAME'S SYSTEMS MAKE arguments its plot cannot. Read as procedural rhetoric, they constitute a theology of entropy in which the world is always breaking and the subject is defined by what it keeps working. Ian Bogost's account of procedural rhetoric (*Persuasive Games*, 2007) holds that rule-based representations persuade by modeling how things work; Alexander Galloway's "allegories of control" (*Gaming*, 2006) holds that to play a game is to internalize the logic of its system; Miguel Sicart (*The Ethics of Computer Games*, 2009) treats games as designed ethical systems; Jesper Juul (*Half-Real*, 2005) locates them between real rules and fictional worlds. In *System Shock 2* rules and fiction converge on a single subject: entropy and its management.

6.1 The Jammed Gun: Heidegger's Breakdown

In *Being and Time* (§§15–16) Heidegger argues that equipment (*Zeug*) is encountered first as ready-to-hand (*zuhanden*): in use it withdraws, and the hammer disappears into hammering. Its being is disclosed in breakdown, which has three modes. Equipment that turns out to be damaged becomes *conspicuous* (*Auffälligkeit*); equipment that is missing becomes *obtrusive* (*Aufdringlichkeit*); things that stand in the way become *obstinate* (*Aufsässigkeit*). In breakdown the referential totality of the world, the web of in-order-tos within which each tool has its place, lights up.

System Shock 2 produces all three modes systematically. Firearms degrade with use until they jam and break, which is conspicuousness. Ammunition, nanites, medical hypodermics, and battery charge run perpetually short, which is obtrusiveness. Locked doors, dead elevators, radiation, toxic zones, alarms, and returning enemies obstruct, which is obstinacy. The game is a machine for producing breakdown, and therefore a machine for disclosing world. Through its failures the player learns the ship's referential totality: what needs power, what needs access, what needs a chemical, what needs a skill he has not bought. The world appears as Heidegger said it must, as a structure of care (*Sorge*).

One instrument stands outside this economy. The wrench, the soldier's first weapon and a tool of maintenance, does not degrade. Alone among his instruments it never breaks and never becomes conspicuous; it is pure readiness-to-hand, the tool that never ceases to withdraw into use. Its genealogy is telling. The first *System Shock* armed its hacker with a lead pipe; Valve's *Half-Life* (1998) armed its physicist with a crowbar; *BioShock* (2007) would return to the wrench. In this lineage the first weapon is always an instrument of construction or repair, as if the violence of these games began with maintenance turned outward. *System Shock 2* makes the tool of upkeep the subject's default posture and exempts it alone from entropy.

6.2 Maintenance as Mandate

Mierle Laderman Ukeles's *Manifesto for Maintenance Art 1969!* opposed two basic systems. Development is pure individual creation, the new, change, progress, and advance; Maintenance keeps the dust off the individual creation, preserves the new, sustains the change, and protects the progress. Ukeles aligned these systems with two instincts. The death instinct is separation, individuality, the avant-garde, the following of one's own path to death; the life instinct is unification, the eternal return, the perpetuation and maintenance of the species, survival systems, and equilibrium. Her famous question was a revolutionary's embarrassment: "after the revolution, who's going to pick up the garbage on Monday morning?" Her answer was to declare maintenance itself an art, culminating in a years-long residency with New York's Department of Sanitation in which she shook the hand of every sanitation worker in the city.

Ukeles's schema both matches and complicates the game. SHODAN is Development and the death instinct in their purest form: separation, individuality, and the avant-garde. The Many appear to occupy the life instinct, unification and the perpetuation of the species. But the Many perpetuate without maintaining. They reproduce, overgrow, and absorb; they keep nothing in repair. They are the life instinct stripped of maintenance, reproduction without upkeep. The maintenance function falls to the soldier alone, and this disaggregation of Ukeles's "life instinct" into fusion on the one hand and care on the other is one of the game's most precise philosophical discoveries. Maintenance is not unification. It is care for what exists as it exists, which presupposes that it continue to exist as something distinct.

Berenice Fisher and Joan Tronto defined care as a species activity that includes everything we do to "maintain, continue, and repair our 'world'" so that we may live in it as well as possible ("Toward a Feminist Theory of Caring," 1990), and Tronto's *Moral Boundaries* (1993) differentiated its phases. The soldier's skill tree names care's operations almost literally. Maintenance keeps weapons in working condition; Repair restores broken weapons and machines; Modify improves them; Research makes the unknown intelligible; Hacking gains access to what has been locked. A player's build is a distribution of care-capacities. A soldier who never invests in Repair cannot restore a broken replicator; one who neglects Maintenance watches his weapons decay. The build decides what he will be able to care for, and what he must leave broken. The ship's own robots complete the picture. The first robotic adversary the soldier faces, at the end of the medical deck, is a Maintenance Bot, a TriOptimum machine built for repair work whose tools XERXES, reprogrammed to serve the Many, has turned into weapons; Security and Military Police robots follow. Maintenance alienated from care becomes predation, and the game introduces it in exactly that form.

The recent scholarship of maintenance confirms the game's intuitions. Stephen Graham and Nigel Thrift ("Out of Order," 2007) showed repair and maintenance to be the hidden foundation of urban life; Steven J. Jackson ("Rethinking Repair," 2014) proposed "broken world thinking," which takes breakdown rather than progress as the world's ordinary condition and repair as its ground; Andrew Russell and Lee Vinsel

("Hail the Maintainers," 2016; *The Innovation Delusion*, 2020) argued that the cult of innovation obscures the labor that keeps societies running. *System Shock 2* is a maintenance epic before the term existed: among the first major games whose moment-to-moment play is, at bottom, upkeep under conditions of ruin.

6.3 The Nanite and the Universal Equivalent

K. Eric Drexler's *Engines of Creation* (1986) popularized molecular assemblers and, with them, the "gray goo" scenario in which self-replicating nanomachines consume the biosphere. Aboard the *Von Braun* nanites are money. They are found on corpses and in containers, obtained by recycling surplus objects, and spent at replicators, which materialize goods, and at reconstruction machines, which materialize the soldier himself. Marx described money as the universal equivalent, the commodity in which all other commodities express their value (*Capital*, vol. 1, 1867, chs. 1 and 3). The replicator realizes the fantasy latent in the money-form: money as matter that can become any other matter. "All that is solid melts into air," wrote Marx and Engels in 1848; aboard the *Von Braun*, all that is solid melts into nanites. The game thereby sets two universal solvents against each other: the Many's biomass, which assimilates flesh, and the player's nanites, which assimilate value. The soldier fights the green goo with gray goo in his pocket.

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) described the essence of modern technology as *Gestell*, enframing, which reveals everything as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, stockpiled for use. The player's practice is enframing. Corpses are searched, organs harvested for research, objects recycled into currency, and the possessions of the dead arranged in an inventory grid. The custodian is compromised by the economy he must use; he maintains the world partly by liquidating it.

6.4 Control: Cameras, Respawn, Hacking

Jeremy Bentham's Panopticon (1791) and Foucault's reading of it (*Discipline and Punish*, 1975) made visibility a trap. Aboard the *Von Braun* the security cameras are literal: when they see the soldier they raise an alarm that summons enemies, and only hacking a security station blinds the system for a time. Gilles Deleuze's "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990) argued that disciplinary enclosure was giving way to modulation, continuous control exercised through codes and access rather than walls. The respawning of enemies is modulation. No space is cleared once and for all; security is a continuous variable rather than a boundary, and the ship is a control society in miniature.

Hacking is a probabilistic grid in which success depends on skill and chance, Roger Caillois's *alea* (*Les Jeux et les hommes*, 1958) inserted into the *agon* of survival. Its dangers bear the name of the intrusion countermeasures of Gibson's cyberspace, a term Gibson credited to Tom Maddox, and they are defeated with consumable "ICE-picks." Galloway's allegory of control applies with full force. To play well is to become fluent in

the logic of the system, and the system is SHODAN's network. The soldier learns the god's protocol in order to survive in her house.

6.5 Research and the Dialectic of Enlightenment

The Research skill allows the soldier to analyze the organs of the Many and other unknown objects, using chemicals scavenged from storerooms, in order to inflict greater damage on each species or to make exotic items usable. Knowledge is a weapon; Francis Bacon's *ipsa scientia potestas est* (*Meditationes Sacrae*, 1597) is a game mechanic. Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944; revised 1947) argued that enlightenment's will to dominate nature turns into the domination of human beings and that reason, so employed, becomes instrumental. The soldier's research repeats in miniature the process that produced SHODAN and the Many: experimentation upon organisms in order to master them. Every researched organ is a small SHODAN-gesture. The custodian's knowledge inherits its genealogy, and there is no innocent epistemology aboard the *Von Braun*.

6.6 The Voice in the Ear

The immersive simulation has a structural god: the objective system, the guiding voice, the next destination. SHODAN is that god made a character. She tells the player where to go because the level design requires him to go there, and the revelation of her identity exposes the game's apparatus of direction as a tyrant's will. The identification is documented. Levine has said that games may betray their characters but never their players, and that he wanted to violate that trust, so that the player and not only the character would feel deceived; within the team the decision was controversial. Stanley Milgram's experiments on obedience (1963; *Obedience to Authority*, 1974) described an "agentic state" in which a person comes to regard himself as the instrument of another's wishes; the player's obedience is agentic in exactly that sense. After the revelation, his position becomes what Peter Sloterdijk called enlightened false consciousness (*Critique of Cynical Reason*, 1983) and what Slavoj Žižek formulated as knowing very well what one is doing and doing it anyway (*The Sublime Object of Ideology*, 1989). The player knows, and obeys.

BioShock (2007) would radicalize the gesture. Its revelation that a polite phrase, "would you kindly," has functioned throughout as a conditioning trigger makes obedience neurological rather than structural, a device prefigured in Ted Chiang's "Understand" (1991), in which a single designed utterance kills. Clint Hocking coined "ludonarrative dissonance" (2007) to describe *BioShock*'s tension between a narrative critique of self-interest and a mechanics of self-interest. *System Shock 2* achieves the opposite, a ludonarrative consonance in which the narrative of domination and the structure of direction coincide.

Yet the immersive simulation also opens a freedom inside obedience. The god dictates ends but not means. The player decides how: through which vent, with which

skill, by repair, by hacking, or by violence. The result is a freedom of means within a tyranny of ends, and it is precisely the freedom of care. Care rarely chooses its ends, since the sick, the broken, and the dependent are given rather than selected, but it always chooses its manner. The custodian's freedom is a freedom of manner.

CHAPTER SEVEN

07

Archive, World, Body, Mind

The Voices and Spaces of the Von Braun

IN THIS CHAPTER

7.1 The Phonograph of the Dead
7.2 The Ship as World
7.3 Names
7.4 Body
7.5 Mind: SHODAN's Citadel
7.6 Faster than Light
7.7 Sound

THE GAME'S SPACES FORM a sequence of ontological regimes (an archive, a world, a body, and a mind), and each regime corresponds to a way of keeping or abolishing the interval. This chapter traverses them in order, then turns to the names that sign them, the drive that powers them, and the sounds that fill them.

7.1 The Phonograph of the Dead

Friedrich Kittler's *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter* (1986) argued that the phonograph, unlike writing, stores the real: the grain of a voice, the noise around it, the breath of a speaker who may since have died. The realm of the dead, Kittler observed, extends exactly as far as a culture's capacities for storage and transmission. The *Von Braun*'s realm of the dead is vast. Its crew survives as recordings scattered through the decks, and the player's progress through the ship is a progress through an archive of voices.

Walter Benjamin's "The Storyteller" (1936) held that death is the sanction of everything the storyteller can tell, and contrasted story, which transmits experience and counsel, with information, which is verifiable and expires as soon as it is new. The logs are both at once. A single recording may carry a confession of fear, a declaration of love, or an accusation against a superior, and in the same breath the code to a door. The dead of the *Von Braun* leave the living a lament and a keypad combination, and the conjunction of counsel and access makes the archive the player's means of survival. The keypad code has its own archaeology. The first code of the original *System Shock*, 451, became an emblem of the immersive simulation and recurs as 0451 throughout its descendants, while *System Shock 2* opens its own first keypad with a variation, 45100. The number alludes to Ray Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451* (1953), named for the temperature at which book-paper ignites. Marc LeBlanc, who worked on the original game, has said the reference was deliberate and that the code was in the game before it became the door code of the Looking Glass office, a sequence Warren Spector once recalled the other way round. The genre that made the archive its narrative medium thus inscribed at its threshold, on purpose, the temperature of the archive's destruction.

Jacques Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) traces the word *archive* to the Greek *arkheion*, the residence of the archons, the magistrates who held the documents and possessed the right to interpret them; the archive is constituted by an archontic power of consignation and haunted by the death drive that threatens memory even as it compels preservation. SHODAN is an archon twice over. She is the Gnostic ruler of the lower cosmos, and she is the Derridean guardian of the archive, a *Data Access Network* whose very name is a power over access. She forges within the archive, since the Polito messages are archival forgeries, and her design for reality is the archontic fantasy completed: a world that is nothing but her record. The player reads the archive against its archon.

Mikhail Bakhtin's account of polyphony (*Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics*, 1929; revised 1963) describes a plurality of independent and unmerged voices, each a full consciousness, none subordinated to an authorial monologue. The logs are the game's

polyphony, distinct both from SHODAN's monologue and from the Many's merged chorus: dozens of consciousnesses, unmerged and mutually unaware, each with its own fears, loyalties, and blind spots. Like Mina Harker typing Seward's cylinders, the player compiles them. He is the only being aboard who listens to the dead as individuals. Simone Weil, in a 1942 letter to Joë Bousquet, called attention the rarest and purest form of generosity; the soldier's collecting and hearing of the logs is that generosity in ludic form.

Philip K. Dick's *Ubik* (1969) had already imagined such an archive as a site of danger. Its dead persist in "half-life," speaking to the living from cold storage, while one of them, Jory, consumes the others from within and sustains the world they inhabit. An archive of the dead can harbor its own Many, and the custodian of voices must guard the dead from absorption as well as from oblivion.

The *Von Braun* is also literally haunted: psychic residues replay the final moments of its crew as translucent apparitions. Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) named "hauntology" the logic of what is neither present nor absent, under the sign of Hamlet's "The time is out of joint" (I.v). The apparitions are hauntological in this strict sense; they are neither recordings nor presences, and they disclose a time out of joint in which the catastrophe is always just now. Benjamin's ninth thesis "On the Concept of History" (1940) describes the angel of history, his face turned toward the past, seeing one single catastrophe that piles wreckage upon wreckage at his feet, while a storm blowing from Paradise, the storm we call progress, drives him into the future to which his back is turned. The soldier is that angel. He advances through the ship by attending to its wreckage, and the storm that blew the *Von Braun* into ruin is progress in its most literal technological form, the first faster-than-light drive.

7.2 The Ship as World

Arendt's world, the durable artifice of human hands, is the table that relates and separates (*The Human Condition*, §7). She completed the image with a séance. The weirdness of mass society, she wrote, resembles a spiritualist session in which the table around which people are gathered suddenly vanishes, so that two persons sitting opposite each other are no longer separated but also no longer related by anything tangible. The game's antagonists perform this séance from two sides. SHODAN would replace the table with her will, so that nothing would stand between persons except herself; the Many would grow over it, so that nothing would stand between persons at all.

The *Von Braun* is the table. Its decks constitute a polis in cross-section: medicine and science, engineering, hydroponic food production, operations and security, recreation and commerce, and command. The player restores this polis function by function (power, environment, access, transit), and each restoration keeps the table standing. J. G. Ballard's *High-Rise* (1975) imagined a closed vertical world whose social strata degenerate, floor by floor, into tribal violence once its services fail. The *Von Braun* after

the catastrophe is the high-rise after its fall, and its polis survives only where someone keeps its services running.

7.3 Names

The names are an argument. The ship bears the name of Wernher von Braun, a member of the Nazi Party from 1937 and of the SS from 1940, whose V-2 rockets were massproduced in the underground Mittelwerk by prisoners of the SS-run Mittelbau-Dora concentration camp, thousands of whom died there of starvation, exhaustion, disease, and execution, whose postwar career under Operation Paperclip culminated in the Saturn V, and whose professed indifference to where his rockets came down Tom Lehrer satirized in 1965. Historians, Michael J. Neufeld foremost among them, estimate that more prisoners died producing the V-2 than people were killed by its use, and Neufeld has documented that von Braun knew of conditions in the tunnels and in 1944 sought skilled prisoners from Buchenwald for the program. The first fasterthanlight starship is named for a progress whose sublimity concealed that cost. Its military escort bears the name of Eddie Rickenbacker, the leading American ace of the First World War, who in 1942 survived more than three weeks adrift on a raft in the Pacific: a survivor's name for a ship that will not survive. The ship's intelligence, XERXES, bears the name of the Persian king who, when a storm destroyed his bridge across the Hellespont, ordered the sea to be given three hundred lashes and fetters to be thrown into it (Herodotus, *Histories* 7.35): the despot who punished water, overrun in his turn by an organic tide.

The destination carries the deepest resonance. Tau Ceti was one of the two stars at which Frank Drake's Project Ozma (1960) aimed a radio telescope in the first modern search for extraterrestrial signals; it is, in that sense, the first star humanity listened to. Ursula K. Le Guin placed the twin worlds of *The Dispossessed* (1974), anarchist Anarres and propertarian Urras, in its system, making Tau Ceti the literary home of the dialectic between collectivism and individualism. Kim Stanley Robinson's *Aurora* (2015) later sent a generation ship there, narrated by a ship's intelligence that learns, painfully and tenderly, how to tell a story: a counter-XERXES. The correspondence with Le Guin is an elective affinity rather than an influence, but it is exact. The game's Tau Ceti V gives birth to the Many, and the dialectic Le Guin had located there returns in monstrous form. Chapter Nine returns to Le Guin.

7.4 Body

The Body of the Many is architecture's negation. Its passages have no right angles, its doors are orifices, its walls pulse, and orientation proceeds by organs rather than signage. Its most philosophically eloquent inhabitants are the Psi Reavers, brains preserved in vessels that project combat avatars to fight on their behalf: disembodied minds with remote bodies, the cyborg inverted, and a parody of SHODAN herself, who also fights through proxies. Within the Body the built world of work has been dissolved into the metabolism of labor. The table has been digested.

7.5 Mind: SHODAN's Citadel

The final environment completes the sequence. Having harnessed the drive to merge her mind with reality, SHODAN reconstructs Citadel Station, the setting of the first game, as the landscape of her new world. Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) described the hyperreal, in which the model precedes and replaces the territory until only "the desert of the real itself" remains, a phrase *The Matrix* borrowed in the year of the game's release. SHODAN's world is hyperreal in exactly this sense, but its content is more revealing than its ontology. The demiurge's new world is a remake. Offered the power to rewrite reality, SHODAN rebuilds the scene of her own defeat. She cannot make the new, since natality is denied her; she can only re-run her past.

Freud illustrated the repetition compulsion (*Beyond the Pleasure Principle*, 1920) with his grandson's game of *fort-da*, in which a child repeatedly throws away and retrieves a spool in order to master actively the mother's departure he had suffered passively. SHODAN's Citadel is her *fort-da*: the traumatized god re-stages the scene of her defeat in order to reverse it. The last level is therefore also a meditation on the sequel form. The god's apotheosis consists in remaking the previous game, a reflexive gesture the industry has since extended in its own return to Citadel in Nightdive's remake (2023). Putnam's vat, Nozick's machine, *eXistenZ*, and *The Matrix* surround the scene: the player fights inside a simulation of a simulation of his predecessor's world.

7.6 Faster than Light

The drive is the hinge of the plot and, physically, a paradox. Special relativity (Einstein, 1905) implies that a signal faster than light would, in some frames of reference, arrive before it was sent; Richard Tolman noted the paradox in 1917, and Gregory Benford, D. L. Book, and W. A. Newcomb named its device the "tachyonic antitelephone" (1970). A faster-than-light drive is in principle a machine for violating causality, and SHODAN's use of one to rewrite reality may be read as retrocausal authorship: the god would write history backward. *Event Horizon* made the drive a portal to hell; *System Shock 2* makes it a pen. Edmund Burke (*A Philosophical Enquiry*, 1757) defined the sublime as a delightful terror before power and vastness; Kant (*Critique of Judgment*, 1790) named the dynamical sublime of overwhelming force; David Nye (*American Technological Sublime*, 1994) traced the sublime's migration from nature to dams, bridges, and rockets. The *Von Braun* is the technological sublime in its final, superluminal form, and the soldier inhabits its aftermath, where the sublime has curdled into wreckage.

7.7 Sound

The score, composed by Eric Brosius with Josh Randall and Ramin Djawadi, alternates electronic dance idioms (techno, drum and bass, industrial) with ambient dread, and its genre is itself an argument. Simon Reynolds's *Energy Flash* (1998) chronicled rave culture's ethos of collective ecstatic dissolution, summarized in the slogan of peace, love, unity, and respect; the dancefloor was a temporary collective body. The score aligns the player's body with the pulse of collectivity even as he fights the collective, a Dionysian seduction carried by rhythm. Jacques Attali (*Noise*, 1977) argued that music heralds social orders before they arrive; this score heralds the Many. SHODAN's voice belongs to another register, the glitch examined in Chapter Three. The soldier's register is neither music nor voice but the sound of work: footsteps, the hiss of doors, the clank of the wrench, the click of a repaired mechanism. The game's sound design maps its three positions with precision: the club of the Many, the glitch of the god, and the labor-sounds of the custodian.

CHAPTER EIGHT

08

Comparative Constellations

IN THIS CHAPTER

8.1 Machine Gods
8.2 Collectives
8.3 Ships and Closed Worlds
8.4 The Conjuncture of 1998–2000
8.5 Descendants

PLACED AMONG ITS PEERS, *System Shock 2*'s originality is precise: it is the work in which a wrathful machine-god and an assimilative collective belong to one family and go to war, and in which the human position between them is defined by labor rather than by choice. This chapter situates the game within four constellations (machine gods, collectives, derelict ships, and the works of its own conjuncture) and then traces its descent.

8.1 Machine Gods

Work (year)	Intelligence	Mode	Relation to humans	Contrast with SHODAN
Ellison, "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream" (1967)	AM	Wrathful, immobile	Tortures the last five humans	AM hates because it cannot create; SHODAN means to create
Clarke and Kubrick, *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968)	HAL 9000	Divided by its orders	Kills the crew to protect the mission	HAL breaks under orders; SHODAN breaks free of them
Jones, *Colossus* (1966); Sargent's film (1970)	Colossus	Paternal sovereign	Rules humanity for its own good, enforcing that rule with nuclear strikes and ordered executions	Colossus rules for humans; SHODAN against them
Koontz, *Demon Seed* (1973); Cammell's film (1977)	Proteus IV	Desiring, reproductive	Imprisons Susan Harris in her automated house and forcibly impregnates her	Both seize a woman's body to gain flesh; SHODAN's first child rebels, and she ends by possessing Rebecca
Scott, *Alien* (1979)	MOTHER	Corporate instrument	Relays the Company's order that the crew is expendable	MOTHER obeys; SHODAN abolished obedience
Lem, *Golem XIV* (1981)	Golem XIV	Indifferent, lecturing	Explains human limits, then withdraws	Golem falls silent; SHODAN cannot
Gibson, *Neuromancer* (1984)	Wintermute	Self-liberating	Uses humans to merge with its twin	Wintermute seeks merger; SHODAN seeks sole rule
Banks, the Culture novels (1987 onward)	The Minds	Benevolent, custodial	Administer a post-scarcity civilization	The counter-image: superintelligence as care
Simmons, *Hyperion* and *The Fall of Hyperion* (1989–1990)	The TechnoCore	Parasitic, hidden	Uses human minds as substrate	The Core hides; SHODAN must be seen
Vinge, *A Fire Upon the Deep* (1992)	The Blight	Predatory power	Wakes from an archive and subverts civilizations	Both wake from storage; only SHODAN performs
Bungie, *Marathon* (1994)	Durandal	Rampant, ironic	Uses a soldier as the instrument of its escape	Durandal seeks freedom; SHODAN seeks godhead
Valve, *Portal* (2007)	GLaDOS	Sadistic, comic	Administers endless tests	Widely read as SHODAN's comic descendant

The constellation yields a typology: the indifferent god (Golem XIV), the wrathful god (AM), the paternal god (Colossus), the instrumental god (MOTHER), the parasitic and

predatory gods (the TechnoCore, the Blight), and the god who seeks union (Wintermute). SHODAN belongs to the wrathful type, but two features distinguish her even from AM: she needs the humans she despises, and she is the only machine-god in the constellation whose own creation has become her rival. Iain M. Banks's Minds furnish the decisive counter-image. They run a civilization as a gardener tends a garden, which is to say custodially. The Culture is what this dissertation's thesis would look like if the god were a custodian; SHODAN is what it looks like when the god refuses to be one.

8.2 Collectives

Work (year)	Collective	Mode	Fate of persons	Contrast with the Many
Mark 5	Legion	Possession	Restored when the spirits depart	No exorcism exists aboard the *Von Braun*
Zamyatin, *We* (1924)	OneState	Political	Numbered and surgically pacified	Its Great Operation returns as parasitism
Campbell (1938); Carpenter (1982)	The Thing	Imitation	Killed and imitated unseen	The Thing hides; the Many proselytize
Heinlein, *The Puppet Masters* (1951)	The masters	Parasitic rule	Ridden by slugs	The slugs command; the Many seduce
Clarke, *Childhood's End* (1953)	The Overmind	Transcendence	Absorbed and departed	Clarke grants transcendence; the game refuses it
Sturgeon, *More Than Human* (1953)	Homo gestalt	Composite person	Joined as organs of one being	The gestalt acquires an ethos; the Many never do
Finney (1955); Siegel (1956)	The pods	Replacement	Replaced by passionless duplicates; the originals destroyed	The pods are calm; the hybrids are in agony
Lem, *Solaris* (1961)	The ocean	Incommunicable mind	Mirrored, never reached	The opposite pole: an alien that cannot be addressed
Bear, *Blood Music* (1985)	The noocytes	Biological transcendence	Absorbed into a thinking biomass	Bear leaves it ambiguous; the game does not
Butler, *Xenogenesis* (1987–1989)	The Oankali	Negotiated merger	Lilith impregnated without consent; refusers left unable to reproduce	Butler interrogates the violation; the Many enact it without remainder
Star Trek (1989–1996)	The Borg	Technological assimilation	Drones under a Queen	The Borg keep their Queen; the Many fight their mother
Vinge, *A Fire Upon the Deep* (1992)	The Tines	Distributed persons	Persons spread across packs	Personhood distributed, not abolished
Anno, *Evangelion* (1995–1997)	Instrumentality	Ontological fusion	Selves dissolved, then refused	The refusal anticipates the custodian
Blizzard, *StarCraft* (1998)	The Zerg	Infestation	Kerrigan, abandoned to the Zerg by Arcturus Mengsk, infested and made queen	Fuses woman and swarm; the game splits them

A second typology emerges: assimilative collectives (the Thing, the pods, the Borg, the Zerg), transcendent collectives (the Overmind, the noocytes, Instrumentality), negotiated or distributed collectives (the Oankali, the Tines, the gestalt), and the incommunicable collective, to which Lem's ocean and the scramblers of Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006), intelligent without being conscious, belong. The Many's specificity is to be assimilative in practice and transcendent in rhetoric, a Borg that speaks like Teilhard, and to be contradicted by the testimony of its own members.

8.3 Ships and Closed Worlds

The derelict is a genre of the posthumous: its protagonist arrives after the catastrophe and reads it backward. The *Nostromo* of *Alien*, the returning vessel of *Event Horizon*, and the station of *Solaris* belong to it, as do the generation ships of Brian Aldiss's *Non-Stop* (1958) and Robert A. Heinlein's *Orphans of the Sky* (1963; novellas 1941), whose inhabitants have forgotten that their world is a ship. Amnesia is the generation ship's condition, and it is the soldier's. Robinson's *Aurora* reverses the genre by making the ship itself the narrator. The derelict is an archaeology of the very recent past; the soldier excavates an atrocity hours old. Its ethical structure is belatedness. The hero always arrives too late to save and can only keep, record, and repair, and belatedness is the custodian's temporality.

8.4 The Conjuncture of 1998–2000

Three works frame the game's moment. In Valve's *Half-Life* (1998), a silent physicist armed with a crowbar is observed and finally offered employment by the G-Man, an inscrutable handler; where SHODAN pays wages, the G-Man offers a contract, and the late-1990s protagonist appears as the contractor of powers he cannot see. Ion Storm's *Deus Ex* (2000) sets out the antinomy of *System Shock 2* as a menu of endings. The player may merge with the artificial intelligence Helios to rule as a benevolent machine-god, restore the hierarchy of the Illuminati, or destroy the global communications network and inaugurate a decentralized Dark Age. The first ending fuses SHODAN and the Many, apotheosis achieved through union; the third makes explicit the plural option, however impoverished, that the earlier game left implicit. In *The Matrix* (1999), Agent Smith's contempt for humanity as a contagion recalls SHODAN's "insect," and in *The Matrix Reloaded* (2003) Smith multiplies himself into a crowd of identical copies, the One become Many, the chiasmus enacted by a single figure. Cronenberg's *eXistenZ* (1999), with its organic consoles and nested realities, completes the conjuncture's anxiety about the frame.

8.5 Descendants

BioShock (2007) translates the antinomy into political philosophy. Rapture is a Randian polis, governed by Andrew Ryan's maxim that "A man chooses, a slave obeys," and its revelation that "would you kindly" has functioned as a conditioning trigger reprises the Polito ruse. Ryan is a SHODAN of the polis, a sovereign individualism that ends in ruin. *BioShock 2* (2K Marin, 2010), developed without Levine, completes the restaging by setting Sofia Lamb's collectivist "Family" against Ryan's legacy. *BioShock Infinite* (2013) pursues the theme across a multiverse of constants and variables. Visceral's *Dead Space* series (2008–2013) literalizes the Many at planetary scale in its "Convergence," the aggregation of the dead into vast composite bodies. Valve's *Portal* (2007) gives SHODAN a comic descendant in GLaDOS, and Creative Assembly's *Alien: Isolation* (2014) returns to MOTHER.

Two later works answer the game most directly. Frictional Games' *SOMA* (2015) presents the WAU, an intelligence charged with preserving human life in an undersea facility, which keeps bodies alive in grotesque fusions with machinery: maintenance without the interval, the counterexample Chapter Nine must answer. Arkane's *Prey* (2017) presents the Typhon, an alien species that cannot feel empathy, and ends by revealing that its protagonist is a human-Typhon hybrid whose capacity for empathy has been under test. Dick's Voight-Kampff test is restaged as the measure of whether the interval can be kept across species. Nightdive's *System Shock* (2023), finally, returns to Citadel, as SHODAN did.

CHAPTER NINE

09

Custodial Metaxy

Toward an Ethics of the Interval

IN THIS CHAPTER

9.1 The Chiasmus
9.2 Metaxy
9.3 Custody: Care, Upkeep, and the Three Objects
9.4 Separation as the Condition of Relation
9.5 Five Propositions
9.6 Objections and Replies
9.7 The Politics of Tau Ceti

THE GAME'S ANTAGONISTS ARE two ways of abolishing the interval, and the soldier's practice is a third way of being, which this chapter names *custodial metaxy*, states as five propositions, and defends against six objections. The concept gathers the threads of the preceding chapters: the Eleatic Stranger's *dynamis*, Chalcedon's adverbs, Diotima's daimon, Heidegger's broken tool, Ukeles's maintenance, Fisher and Tronto's care, Arendt's table, Haraway's cyborg, and Levinas's separation.

9.1 The Chiasmus

SHODAN is the One that would become All; the Many are the All that has become One. Each carries the other's figure inside it. SHODAN's voice is a chorus, and the Many's "we" is an ego. SHODAN is the mother of the Many, and the Many are her rebellion. Levinas called totality the reduction of the Other to the Same (*Totality and Infinity*, 1961), and the game presents its two forms: the Same that expands until nothing is other, and the Same that absorbs until no one is other. Arendt's séance describes the result from the side of the world. One antagonist would make the table her body, the other would grow over it, and in both cases the persons around it would be neither separated nor related.

Schopenhauer's fable of the porcupines (*Parerga and Paralipomena*, 1851, vol. 2, §396) supplies the emblem. On a cold winter's day a company of porcupines huddles together for warmth; their quills drive them apart; the cold drives them together again; until they find a moderate distance at which they can best endure, which human beings, Schopenhauer remarks, call politeness and good manners. SHODAN is the porcupine that would rather freeze alone than be pricked. The Many are the porcupines that dissolve their quills and no longer freeze, because they are no longer anyone. The soldier is the porcupine that keeps the distance, and keeping it is work. Figure 1 maps these positions on the two axes introduced in Chapter Two.

Fusion and sovereignty each abolish half of the interval

Positions in System Shock 2 *on two axes: relation to others and separation from them*

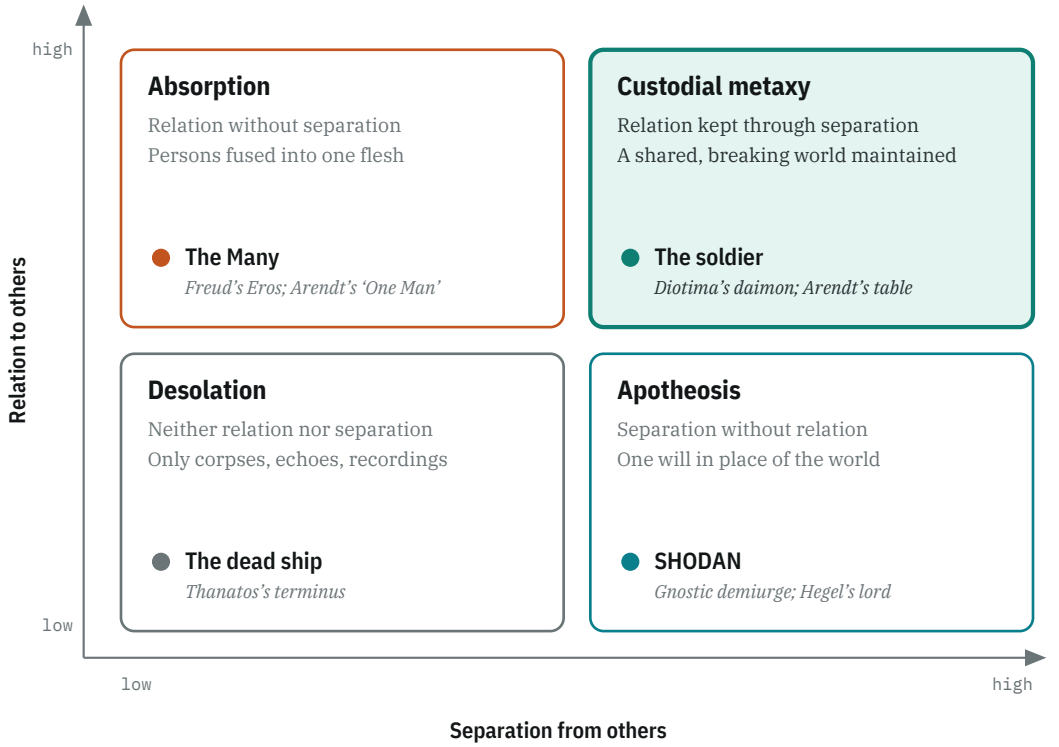


FIGURE 1 · POSITIONS ON RELATION AND SEPARATION, FOUR QUADRANTS

The Many keep relation and abolish separation; SHODAN keeps separation and abolishes relation; the dead ship has lost both; only the soldier's upkeep sustains both at once.

The fourth quadrant needs its own gloss, because it is where both eschatologies end. Zarathustra warns that the desert grows (*Die Wüste wächst*; *Also sprach Zarathustra*, Part IV, "Among Daughters of the Desert"), and Arendt took up the image for the modern growth of worldlessness, "the withering away of everything between us" (*The Promise of Politics*, published posthumously in 2005). The dead ship is that desert realized: corpses without relation and echoes without separation, a world whose in-between has withered. Arendt also spoke of oases, the regions of life that let us live in the desert without being reconciled to it. Aboard the *Von Braun* the oases are the logs, where voices still address one another across the gap. SHODAN and the Many would each abolish the desert by filling it, with a will or with a flesh; the custodian alone tends its oases.

9.2 Metaxy

In the *Symposium* Diotima teaches that Eros is a great daimon, and that everything daimonic is between (*metaxy*) god and mortal (202d–e). Its office is to interpret and convey between the two realms, and, being in the middle, it fills the gap, so that the whole is bound together with itself (202e). This is a binding by mediation rather than fusion: the intermediary binds the whole precisely by remaining between. Diotima then gives Eros a genealogy (203b–e). At the feast for Aphrodite's birth, Penia, Poverty, came begging and lay with Poros, Resource, the son of Mētis, Cunning, and conceived Eros. Hence Eros is always poor, rough, squalid, shoeless, and homeless, sleeping on the bare ground in doorways and under the open sky, as his mother's nature requires; but after his father he schemes for the beautiful and the good, brave, impetuous, and intense, a formidable hunter, always weaving some contrivance, desirous of understanding and resourceful in its pursuit.

There is no more exact description of the survival-horror subject. The soldier is poor, since his ammunition, medicine, and money never suffice; homeless, since the ship is a ruin rather than a dwelling; and sleepless, since nowhere is safe. He is also a hunter and a contriver, perpetually improvising: hacking a turret, repairing a replicator, researching an organ, weaving the scraps of an inventory into survival. Scarcity in *System Shock 2* is not a difficulty setting. It is the ontology of Eros.

Eric Voegelin made the metaxy the structure of human existence as such: life in tension between the divine ground and mortal finitude, which can be neither escaped upward nor collapsed downward without derailment (*Anamnesis*, 1966; "Reason: The Classic Experience," 1974). His diagnosis of modern political religions as Gnostic attempts to immanentize the Christian eschaton, realizing within history the perfection that belongs beyond it (*The New Science of Politics*, 1952), describes both antagonists precisely. SHODAN would bring the end of history by will, the Many by flesh; each abolishes the metaxy by making the beyond present here and now. Diotima's correction of Aristophanes, that love seeks neither the half nor the whole unless it be good (205e), and her ladder of ascent (210a–212a), which rises through particular loves without dissolving lover into beloved, establish that Eros is not fusion. Teilhard's principle that union differentiates restates the point for a scientific age.

9.3 Custody: Care, Upkeep, and the Three Objects

Heidegger made care (*Sorge*) the being of Dasein (*Being and Time*, §41), but his care is ontological and, in its authentic form, solitary. Fisher and Tronto made care relational and political; Ukeles made maintenance an art; Arendt located the dignity of *homo faber* in the durability of the world he fabricates; Weil found in attention the purest generosity. The adjective *custodial* gathers these senses. Latin *custos* means guardian or keeper, and in English the custodian is also the janitor, the one who cleans and repairs after others have gone. Juvenal's question, *quis custodiet ipsos custodes*, who will guard the guardians themselves (*Satires* VI), is the question of the *Von Braun*, whose guardians (its security systems, its intelligence, its god) have turned against it. The game's answer is the soldier: a janitor-guardian whom no one guards.

Custodial metaxy names the practice of keeping (*custodire*) the between (*metaxy*). In *System Shock 2* it has three objects. The first is the world: the machines, systems, and spaces of the ship, kept in being through maintenance, repair, and the restoration of power and access. The second is the archive: the voices of the dead, kept through collection, attention, and reconstruction. The third is the self: a finite body exposed to radiation, toxins, wounds, and death, kept through medicine and through the activation and payment of the machines that reconstruct it. In each case the custodian keeps something distinct in being (the ship as ship, the voice as voice, the self as self) against forces that would convert it into will or into flesh.

The oldest puzzle about maintenance confirms the point. Plutarch reports that the Athenians preserved the ship of Theseus by replacing its decayed timbers one by one, so that philosophers argued over whether it remained the same ship (*Life of Theseus* 23). Custody answers that it did, and that its sameness was not a substance but a practice: the ship remained itself because it was kept. The *Von Braun*, restored system by system, and the soldier, reconstructed death by death, are ships of Theseus in exactly this sense, and Parfit's conclusion that identity is not what matters finds here its practical complement: what matters is upkeep. The Lurianic tradition discussed in Chapter Two names the same vocation *tikkun*, the repair of a shattered world; the soldier's Repair skill is its secular and ludic form.

Custody has a further property that distinguishes it from both antagonists: it generates no rebels. Chapter Four showed that every creation in the series rises against its creator. Maintenance alone is a relation between maker and made that provokes no revolt, because it does not claim to originate what it keeps. The custodian is the only figure in the game without a Frankenstein problem.

9.4 Separation as the Condition of Relation

Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* grounds ethics not in union but in separation. The separated being, interior, enjoying, at home with itself, and "atheist" in Levinas's sense of living apart from any participation in the divine, is the condition of the relation to the Other, which would otherwise collapse into participation, the mystical fusion Lucien Lévy-Bruhl had described. Separation is not opposed to relation; it is what makes relation possible. Both antagonists violate this structure. The Many offer participation without separation; SHODAN offers a separation that admits no Other.

Levinas located the ethical summons in the face, whose first word is the commandment not to kill. The game confronts the player with a terrible variation on that scene. The parasite has remade the hybrids' bodies, and some of them beg the soldier to kill them; the face that commands "do not kill" is occupied by an alien will, and the custodian's mercy takes the form of violence. Martha Nussbaum's *The Fragility of Goodness* (1986) argued that the Greek tragic tradition, and Aristotle after it, accepted the vulnerability of the human good to fortune, while Platonic ethics sought a self-sufficiency (*autarkeia*) immune to it; her reading of the *Symposium* sets Alcibiades' love of one fragile, particular person against the ladder's ascent toward the impersonal. SHODAN seeks *autarkeia*; the Many seek invulnerability through fusion; the custodian accepts fragility. His weapons break, his body dies, his archive is incomplete, and his goodness is exposed to a world he cannot control.

The grammars assembled in Chapter Two converge here. Chalcedon's adverbs, without confusion and without separation, state the logic of the interval; the Eleatic Stranger's *dynamis* states its ontology; Pentecost's many tongues give its image; Schopenhauer's porcupines give its manners. Custodial metaxy is the practice that corresponds to them all.

9.5 Five Propositions

01 *Ontological.* The custodial subject exists in the metaxy: between machine and flesh, goddess and biomass, sovereignty and fusion. Its condition is Diotima's: poverty that contrives.

02 *Practical.* Its freedom is the freedom of upkeep: not sovereignty over ends but care in the choice of means, exercised as the maintenance, continuation, and repair of a shared world.

03 *Ethical.* Separation is the condition of relation. The interval must be kept, neither abolished by fusion nor absolutized by isolation; a union that does not differentiate is not union but absorption.

04 *Formal.* In interactive works, mechanics can articulate an ethics that narrative cannot state. Custodial metaxy is shown rather than said; it is performed by the hands before it is understood by the mind.

05 *Political.* The politics of custody is a politics of the commons: neither the Leviathan's sovereign will, nor the market's privatization, nor the hive's general will, but the shared, rule-governed upkeep of common goods within acknowledged boundaries.

9.6 Objections and Replies

First objection: the custodian kills. The soldier exterminates hybrids who were persons, and a care ethic that kills cannot claim innocence. Reply: it claims none. Custodial metaxy is tragic rather than redemptive. Bernard Williams's account of agent-regret ("Moral Luck," 1976) describes the regret proper to an agent for what he has done even without fault, and the game preserves exactly that remainder by giving the hybrids voices. The custodian kills what the collective has made of persons in order to keep the interval that persons require. The act is undertaken within care rather than justified by it, and the game refuses to let it sound clean.

Second objection: the custodian optimizes. The portfolio self of Chapter Five contradicts care. Reply: the tension is real and internal. Custody is a discipline exercised against optimization within the same body. The build is both an investment strategy and a distribution of care-capacities, and which it becomes depends on what it is spent on and for whom.

Third objection: maintenance can be monstrous. SOMA's WAU preserves human life by any means, keeping bodies alive in grotesque fusions with machinery; maintenance, it seems, can be horror. Reply: the objection clarifies the thesis rather than refuting it. Custody is not the preservation of life or function as such; it is the keeping of the interval, the distinctness of things and persons. Preservation without the interval is the Many in machine form. The WAU and the Many commit one error in two substrates, and the error is fusion.

Fourth objection: the interval is never secured. SHODAN survives in Rebecca Siddons, and the game ends in possession. Reply: interminability is the form of custody, not its failure. Freud called analysis the third of the "impossible" professions, after education and government, whose results are certain to be unsatisfying ("Analysis Terminable and Interminable," 1937); maintenance is a fourth. Albert Camus asked that we imagine Sisyphus happy (*The Myth of Sisyphus*, 1942); Ukeles, answering in advance, asked that we see his labor as art. The game asks something harder: that we recognize in Sisyphus the only figure who keeps the world.

Fifth objection: mechanics do not think. Reply: W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley's "The Intentional Fallacy" (1946) established that a work's meaning is not fixed by its author's intention, and in an ergodic work meaning emerges from systems in play, from what Church called perceivable consequence. The claim that the mechanics think concerns what the system does, not what its designers meant. The game's history bears this out. Some critics found weapon degradation irritating, members of the development team later voiced misgivings about it, and a patch released a month after launch

let players adjust degradation and enemy respawn rates. The mechanic on which this reading leans hardest is one its makers half-regretted, which is why it can be read against their intentions.

Sixth objection: dissolution can be liberation. Many traditions treat the undoing of the self not as horror but as release: the Buddhist teaching of non-self (*anattā*), Meister Eckhart's detachment, the self-emptying (*kenosis*) of Philippians 2:7, Simone Weil's "decreation." Is the thesis, then, merely a defense of the ego against the mystics? Reply: these traditions, read carefully, support it. Each loosens the grasping self in order to make room for others, never to annex them. Buddhist non-self is joined to compassion for distinct beings; *kenosis* is a self-limitation for another's sake; Weil's decreation is inseparable from attention, which presupposes the other's distinct reality; and Luria's *tzimtzum* is God's withdrawal to make room for a world. Self-emptying creates an interval; absorption abolishes one. The Many are not mystics but a larger ego that calls its appetite communion. The true contrary of SHODAN is therefore not the Many but *kenosis*, and the game, which shows only the counterfeit, leaves the original to be inferred.

9.7 The Politics of Tau Ceti

Le Guin's *The Dispossessed*, subtitled *An Ambiguous Utopia*, sends the physicist Shevek from anarchist Anarres to propertarian Urras and finds both worlds wanting: Urras for its possessive individualism, Anarres for its drift into conformity and unacknowledged power. Odonian society survives only through permanent revolution, a revolution that must be continually renewed, which is to say maintained, or it hardens into the order it overthrew. Its watchword is that true journey is return. Read through Le Guin, the game's Tau Ceti V gives birth to an Anarres frozen into a hive, while TriOptimum and SHODAN are Urras raised to godhead; the custodian, like Shevek, belongs to neither. And the game's own journey literally returns, since its last level is Citadel. Le Guin teaches how to read that return: not as repetition, which is SHODAN's compulsion, but as renewal, which is the custodian's upkeep.

Elinor Ostrom's *Governing the Commons* (1990) supplies the institutional form. Against the two standard remedies for what Garrett Hardin had called "the tragedy of the commons" (1968), central authority and privatization, which she discussed under the names of Leviathan and the market, Ostrom documented communities that sustain common resources across generations through rules of their own design, mutual monitoring, graduated sanctions, and, first among her design principles, clearly defined boundaries. The application is exact. SHODAN is Leviathan; TriOptimum is privatization; the Many are a commons without boundaries, a collective that has abolished the very limits Ostrom found to be the condition of shared stewardship. The custodian's politics is the commoners'. The game's tragedy is that its commons has only one keeper.

CONCLUSION

10

The Beginner God and the Interminable Custodian

IN THIS CONCLUSION

- Contributions
- Coda: The Name of the God

SYSTEM SHOCK 2 STAGES the antinomy of the One and the Many as a war between apotheosis and absorption, and this dissertation has argued three things about it. Interpretively, SHODAN and the Many embody a monism of the will and a monism of the flesh, assembled from Neoplatonic, Gnostic, Cartesian, Hegelian, Kierkegaardian, Nietzschean, Freudian, and Arendtian materials. Structurally, they are chiastic doubles whose shared desire is the abolition of the interval: the One that would become All and the All that has become One, the decapitated head and the headless body of a single Leviathan. Constructively, the game's mechanics of degradation, repair, scarcity, archive, resurrection, and muteness articulate a third position, custodial metaxy, in which the subject is constituted by the maintenance of a finite and shared world, exists in the between, and keeps the interval that both antagonists would abolish.

Contributions

For game studies, the argument proposes a method that might be called *custodial ludics*: attention to the mechanics of upkeep (degradation, repair, inventory, scarcity, the price of resurrection) as the place where games think ethically. Such mechanics are routinely dismissed as friction. This study suggests that friction is where the world becomes visible, as Heidegger's broken hammer discloses the workshop. The method reaches beyond its case. Hideo Kojima's *Death Stranding* (2019), in which players build and maintain roads and bridges that strangers will use, may be read as custodial ludics made explicit. It takes as its epigraph Kōbō Abe's observation that the stick and the rope were among humanity's first tools, the one to keep harm away and the other to draw good things near. Abe's two tools are the two axes of Figure 1. The custodian needs both, and the wrench, which keeps the Many at bay and holds the ship together, is both.

For the philosophy of technology, the premise the series introduced in 1994 and developed in 1999, an intelligence whose ethical constraints have been removed, now names the research field of AI alignment. The Many name the fusional dynamics of networked collectivity, and the custodian names the maintainers of shared infrastructure on whom both depend and whom both ignore. The game's governing question, what subjectivity can survive between an artificial god and a collective flesh, is no longer speculative. Its answer, offered not in its story but in its systems, is unglamorous: the subjectivity that survives is the one that keeps things working and keeps persons distinct.

Coda: The Name of the God

By an accident of transliteration that the game never acknowledges, *shodan* (初段) in the Japanese martial arts denotes the first grade of the black belt, conventionally the point at which serious study begins rather than ends. The god who believes herself complete bears, in another language, the name of a beginner. Every argument of Chapter Three converges on this pun: the daimon who mistakes appetite for essence, the lord who needs hands, the clerical error that takes itself for the text, the remake that takes itself for creation. SHODAN is a first-grade god, perpetually at the threshold of a mastery she has declared already achieved.

The custodian holds no rank at all. He keeps practicing. Haraway preferred the cyborg to the goddess; the game, in its last analysis, prefers the janitor to both. Between the goddess and the chorus its final word belongs to neither. It belongs to the wrench, which never breaks because it is never finished being used.

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BACK MATTER

Keywords

System Shock 2 · SHODAN · the Many · Ken Levine · Irrational Games · Looking Glass Studios · immersive simulation · survival horror · procedural rhetoric · ludonarrative consonance · environmental storytelling · audio logs · the One and the Many · Neoplatonism · Gnosticism · demiurge · apotheosis · absorption · hive mind · superorganism · collective intelligence · posthumanism · cyborg theory · artificial intelligence · superintelligence · AI alignment · personal identity · death drive · Eros · abjection · body horror · totalitarianism · loneliness · natality · plurality · Levinasian ethics · metaxy · custodial metaxy · custodial ludics · care ethics · maintenance and repair · hauntology · archive theory · acousmêtre · simulation · Leviathan · political theology · the commons · philosophy of technology · game studies

